Saturday, February 10, 2024
Magh 27, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Shillathwo Paru

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

risingnepaldaily.com
Vol. LIX, No. 52 | Pages 8 | Rs. 5 | National Edition

THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

DEMOCRACY DAY TO BE MARKED FOR THREE DAYS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

The government has decided to celebrate Democracy Day 2024 by organising various programmes across the country for three days.

A meeting of the Democracy Day Main Celebration Committee chaired by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' held in Singha Durbar on Friday decided to mark Democracy Day by organising different programmes on February 18, 19 and 20.

Nepali people have been marking Falgun 7 (February 19) as Democracy Day to commemorate the establishment of democracy in Nepal by overthrowing the 104-year-old family rule of the Ranas on Falgun 7, 2007 BS (February 18, 1951).

The revolution of 1951 was the biggest political movement launched by the Nepali people and backed by the king, which not only ushered in democracy in Nepal but also changed the 'ruled' status of Nepalis into Nepali people.

All the political movements launched thereafter were only to institutionalise or restore the achievements of the epoch-making revolution of 1951.

» SEE PAGE 6

CABINET EXPANDED IN KOSHI

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Feb. 9

Four months after assuming his office, Chief Minister of Koshi Province Kedar Karki gave full shape to his cabinet by appointing four ministers and two state ministers on Friday.

Chief Minister Karki appointed two ministers and two state ministers from the Nepali Congress, and two ministers from the CPN (Maoist Centre).

The newly appointed ministers included Pradip Kumar Sunuwar and Ramkumar Khatri from the Nepali Congress and Narayan Bahadur Burja Magar and Rajendra Kumar Karki from the CPN (Maoist Centre). Indira Thapa and Sunita Kumari Gurung from the Nepali Congress are appointed as state ministers.

Sunuwar is appointed Minister for Health and Khatri Minister for Industry, Agriculture and Cooperative. Likewise, Burja Magar is appointed as Minister for Social Development and Karki as Minister for Drinking Water and Irrigation.

Chief Minister Karki has appointed Indira Thapa as the state minister for Economic Affairs and Planning and Sunita Gurung as the state Minister for Internal Affairs and Law.

Province Chief Parshuram Khapung administered the oath of office and secrecy to the four ministers while Chief Minister Karki administered the oath to the two state ministers.



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Kuinekhani, a traditionally built village, of Raghuganga Rural Municipality in Myagdi district.

Outstanding domestic debt reaches 20.91% of GDP

Public debt may reach Rs. 437 bn next year: Finance Minister

BY MODNATH DHAKAL
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

The outstanding domestic debt (ODD) of Nepal is at 20.91 per cent of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) of the country in 2022, which is above any other South Asian peers except for Bhutan.

A study conducted by Chandra Ghimire and Prajol Joshi for the Management Association of Nepal (MAN) reported that the total outstanding domestic loan of Nepal by the end of the Fiscal Year 2022/23 was Rs. 1125.18 billion which is 81.66 per cent of the annual budget of that year.

The size of the GDP of Nepal last year was Rs. 5381.33 billion.

Presenting the findings of the reports at the conference, Ghimire, who is also a former Commerce Secretary of the Government of Nepal, said that the fast-growing size of domestic debt in the fiscal deficit gives an impression that fiscal discipline has become an issue of deep concern.

"Fiscal resources are scarce and, if not employed prudent approaches in their allocation, in addition to wasting the resources, it may risk the economy of inflation and interest rates," he said.

According to the study, the big and fast shift from external debt to domestic debt while utilising the public debt by the government is the manifestation of its choice to an easier option given the fact that the domestic debt is relatively easier to mobilise with the least conditions or covenants to fulfil.

It maintained that the government's capacity of mobilising resources from external sources is waning away day by day. "For these reasons, decision-makers should be opting for domestic debt over the public debt," read the report.

Speaking at the programme, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat, said that although Nepal was in a comfortable position, but growing use of public debt is a matter of concern.



The size of debt began to grow during the Maoist insurgency as the size of security agencies increased and was further fueled by the COVID-19 pandemic.

According to him, the size of debt began to grow during the Maoist insurgency as the size of security agencies increased and was further fueled by the COVID-19 pandemic. During those periods, revenue collection was poor and the government faced resource crises.

"In terms of social security, we are above any other South Asian country except Sri Lanka. The Constitution of the country has opened a very large scope for social security," he said.

FM Dr. Mahat said that reducing capital expenditure is a matter of worry while government debt servicing liability would reach Rs. 437 billion in the next Fiscal Year 2024/25 and Rs. 500 billion in FY 2025/26.

It will have a serious impact on capital expenditure and its size would be reduced in response, he said. However, proper use of loans and assurance of return will have a positive impact on the economy.

However, on the contrary, better budget mobilisation will increase the size of public debt as well as the government need to mobilise more resources to finance development projects and other social initiatives.

Dr. Yubaraj Khatiwada, former Finance Minister, said that internal loan increase was also fueled by factors like blockade, COVID-19 and economic recession in the post-COVID scenario. Decreased revenue is the root cause of increased public debt, he added, suggesting recurrent expenditure and social security must not be financed by the loans.

"Attracting Foreign Direct Investment at a significant size could be a solution toward reducing the size of the loan," said Dr. Khatiwada, "We have fiscal space. The average loan size of a developing country is around 60 per cent while Nepal has just 42 per cent against the GDP."

Likewise, Bhuwan Dahal, former President of Nepal Banker Association (NBA), said that the banks and financial institutions lack funds to provide debt to the government as they have already mobilised a significant size of funds to the public sector.

The banks have to recover the outstanding credit from the government to provide further loan support, he said.

Economist Keshav Acharya said that there was no clear explanation of the reason behind the increasing size of domestic loans and their utilisation and contribution to the national economy.

"This is worrisome. Actual capital formation of the development expenditure is going down," he said.

Delay in fulfilling the requirement for the disbursement of the development projects implemented in cooperation with the development partners has also caused the growth in public debt, said Acharya.

Tradition of copying previous budget will be terminated: PM

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 9



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the process to bring about ' significant' changes in the national budget system has been taken forward.

In a discussion with the experts related to development and planning at the Office of the Prime Minister and Council of Ministers at Singha Durbar on Friday, PM Dahal argued that the traditional budgetary system had been an obstruction to the transformation of the country.

Mentioning that every year new budget would be introduced as the 'photocopy' of the previous year's budget, the PM expressed commitment that the government would prepare the budget based on priorities after debating, discussing and soliciting suggestions from all sectors on the government's policies, programmes and budget.

According to him, the policies and programmes would be first sent to public, intelligentsia and people's representatives for their review. "The President will read it in the budget only after finalising it," he said.

Stating that the questions raised by the thematic experts would be important, the PM clarified that today's discussion was held as a part of the process of revising the policy, programme and framework and schedule of the budget.

Reminiscing that he had assumed the leadership of the government at the time when there was an economic crisis in the country and attempts were made to raise questions on the republican system, the PM said that he was responsible for resolving the crisis. "I am constantly trying to free the country from the crisis" he asserted.

He added that discussions were held to make three-tier government more effective. "We cannot strengthen the current system until the provincial and local level governments are made stronger. We are serious about it."

In the discussion held in coordination with the National Planning Commission, experts from various fields had furnished suggestions on the course of actions that the government should determine. Commission's Vice-Chairperson Min Bahadur Shrestha shared that the draft of the 16th Periodic Plan was being prepared keeping in consideration increasing production and creating jobs, as he added, that these largely address many issues of the economy.

Participants, furnishing a host of suggestions to the government, said that the process of picking plans should be stopped from taking in an ad-hoc and access-oriented manner.

They spoke of the need to prepare a plan to transform the informal economy into formal and taking into account issues such as trade, finance and foreign exchange liberalisation besides mulling increasing the access of the majority of people to means of production among others.

Nepal, Australia sign trade & investment agreement

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

Minister for Foreign Affairs Narayan Prakash Saud held a bilateral meeting with Australia's Minister for Foreign Affairs Penny Wong in Perth, Australia, on Friday.

According to a statement issued by the Embassy of Nepal in Canberra, during the meeting, the two ministers exchanged views on matters of mutual interest and expressed their happiness over the steadily growing bilateral relations between Nepal and Australia.

After the meeting, both ministers witnessed the signing and exchange of the 'Trade and Investment Framework Arrangement (TIFA) between the two countries. The signing event occurred in the margins of the Seventh Indian Ocean Conference, held in Perth, Australia, from February 9 to 10, 2024.

Ambassador of Nepal to Australia, Kailash Raj Pokharel, and Tim Watts MP, Australia's Assistant Minister for Foreign Affairs signed the TIFA. "The Arrangement aims to promote and deepen bilateral economic relations between Nepal and Australia by encouraging and facilitating trade and investment," read the statement.

Australia is Nepal's sixth-largest foreign investment partner and an international destination of choice for higher education and vocational training for Nepali students.

Australia is supporting Nepal's tourism industry recovery. Almost 39,000 Australians visited Nepal in 2023, making Australia Nepal's fifth largest source of foreign tourists. Nepal's export of services to Australia jumped from $78 million to $160 million in 2022-23, led by strong growth in travel

» SEE PAGE 6

Koshi govt seals five-point deal with agitating ethnic groups

BY SASHIDHAR PARAJULI
Biratnagar, Feb. 9

A five-point agreement was inked between the Koshi province government and the Struggle Committee formed on the renaming of Province No. 1 on Friday.

The talks that began on Thursday concluded on Friday after both sides reached a five-point agreement.

The ethnic groups had been protesting against the naming of Koshi province for about a year.

In the talks, it was agreed that both parties will advance political and constitutional initiatives and discussions to create a political environment in which there will be an agreement regarding the renaming of the province.

In the meeting, the agitating party agreed to change the nature of the protest.

In the second point of the agreement, it was said that "the agitating party will change the nature of the movement and advance peaceful political activities and no force will be used on behalf of the government."

Similarly, the two parties agreed that the provincial government would arrange the treatment of the injured during the identity movement and compensation for the families of the martyrs.

During the agitation, the provincial government agreed to release those who were in jail in various cases and to proceed with the process of withdrawing the cases.

It has been agreed between the government negotiation team and the identification party joint struggle committee to re-negotiate before February 22 and set the date for another round of talks by developing a mutual agreement.

The meeting, which started at 8:00 am on Friday ended at 1:00 pm by

» SEE PAGE 6

32 % wholesale, retail outlets operating without registration: Survey

BY LAXMAN KAFLE
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

About 68 per cent of business establishments are registered with a government agency and 32 per cent are unregistered, according to Nepal Distributive Trade Survey, 2022.

The National Statistics Office (NSO) conducted the Nepal Distributive Trade Survey, 2022 (NDTS) to estimate economic indicators of the wholesale and retail trade sector for the national account estimation, including trade margin of goods and collect information on income, expenditure, investment, employment and compensation to the employees with 15,299 sample trade establishments.

The NDTS-2022 was the second such type of survey conducted after a gap of 14 years. The first distributive trade survey was conducted in 2008.

Launching the report on Friday, chief statistician at NSO Toyam Raya said that the objective of the survey was to measure the contribution of the wholesale and retail trade sector to the national economy as well as provide key indicators such as number of employees, salaries and wages, trade margin and income and expenditure of the trade establishments in Nepal.

The survey has found that 68.2 per cent of trade establishments (wholesale and retail trade and repair motor vehicles and motorcycles) are registered in government agencies whereas 31.8 per cent remain unregistered.

The survey has covered all types of trade activities including motor trade and repair, wholesale and retail trades, he said. The survey has found that 68.2 per cent of trade establishments (wholesale and retail trade and repair motor vehicles and motorcycles) are registered in government agencies whereas 31.8 per cent remain unregistered.

Notably, Madhes Province has the highest proportion of unregistered establishments at 48.2 per cent while Bagmati has comparatively fewer unregistered establishments at 24.7 per cent.

The number of registered trade establishments was 44 per cent in Nepal Economic Census 2018. As per the NEC, there were around 498,058 wholesale and retail trade establishments.

This indicates a significant increase in establishment registration during the period. The encouragement of local levels for registration might be a cause for the increase in registered establishments. In the retail trade sector, a significant 33.4 per cent of establishments are operating without formal registration under any regulatory authority.

An average 2 persons engaged in an establishment

According to the report, a total of 113,0645 persons have engaged in the wholesale and retail trade sector. Out of them, 64 per cent (726,681 persons) were males while 36 per cent (403,964 persons) were females. On average two persons engage in an establishment.

The survey showed that 88.65 per cent of persons were involved in retail trade while 5.8 per cent were associated with motor trade and repair industries and 5.54 per cent in wholesale trade establishments.

Of the total persons engaged in this sector, only about one-fifth are paid. The average annual wages and salaries per paid employee is Rs. 208, 494 (Rs. 17,374 per month). Among the total engaged individuals, the highest proportion, 32.90 per cent was employed in Bagmati Province followed by Koshi with 16.84 per cent.

Likewise, of them, 16.34 per cent were employed in Lumbini and 14.29 per cent in Madhes Province.

The lowest percentage of engagement in this sector was observed in Karnali Province, with only 4.21 per cent. Additionally, Sudurpashchim Province had 5.92 per cent engagement while Gandaki had 9.46 per cent involvement.

Trade margin in Gandaki Province at 20.09 %

The report found that the national

» SEE PAGE 6

New budget will focus on production, job creation: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the upcoming budget will focus on increasing production and job creation.

Addressing the 8th Nuwakot Festival on Friday, the PM made it clear that the budget would be formulated to increase agricultural production.

The PM said that the process of radical change in the national budget system is underway, and the traditional budget system would be transformed, according to a statement received from the secretariat of Prime Minister Prachanda.

He said that work was underway to discuss and collect suggestions from all sectors for the government's upcoming policies and programmes and budget preparation.

"The indicators of the economy are very encouraging, the foreign exchange reserves and the arrival of tourists have increased," said Prime Minister Prachanda. "This has helped bring the economy in the right direction. The revenue mobilisation has also improved recently."

Stating that the budget preparation work was moving forward, the Prime Minister assured that Nuwakot would get priority in policies and programmes.

The Prime Minister said that the government would support the development of religious, historical monuments, agriculture, tourism, business and art culture sectors. He said that the government would pay attention to the reconstruction of the Nuwakot Palace.



PHOTO: TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' at the 8th Nuwakot Festival on Friday.

On the occasion, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry Chandra Prasad Dhakal asked the government to make the dialogue council more active according to the suggestions of the private sector to keep the economy running by boosting the morale of businessmen and general consumers.

He said, "It is necessary to make the council more agile and active to increase the morale of businessmen and general consumers while making the economy viable."

"Now all the external indicators of the economy are fine. A significant amount of remittance has flowed into the country. Foreign currency reserves have also increased. Despite this, the morale of common consumers, businessmen and investors has not increased. Therefore, it is necessary to revive the economy by making the dialogue council which is active under the leadership of the Prime Minister further active," Dhakal said.

It is more difficult to operate airport than building it: Kirati

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gaighat, Feb. 9

Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kirati, has said that the construction of the proposed Everest Domestic Airport will proceed immediately.

After conducting an on-site inspection of the airport construction area at Triyuga Municipality-2 Jogidaha in Udaipur on Friday, he directed Director General of the Civil Aviation Authority of Nepal (CAAN), Pradeep Adhikari to expedite the construction work of the infrastructure.

"The lack of budget is affecting the construction work even after clearing the land in the area where the runway will be constructed by cutting down about 14,000 trees of the Kang and Mothiyahi Community Forests located in Jogidah of Triyuga-1.

Minister Kirati said that the government did not allocate funds under any heading for the construction of the airport's physical infrastructure in the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 but the Ministry has arranged an amount of Rs. 50 million through the CAAN to continue the construction works of the airport.

He said that with that amount, extracting the roots of felled trees, management of ditches and fencing can be done as far as possible. However, Minister Kirati said that due to limited resources, it is not easy to build an airport in a country like Nepal and it is becoming more difficult to operate such a facility than to build it.

The lack of budget is affecting the construction work even after clearing the land in the area where the runway will be constructed by cutting down about 14,000 trees of the Kang and Mothiyahi Community Forests located in Jogidah of Triyuga-1.

According to him, the other 22 airports now under construction could not be operated. "So this airport cannot be operated only targeting the locals of Udayapur, Bhojpur and Khotang, so cross-border flights and mountain flights should be done to operate this airport properly," he said.

Chairman of the Airport Construction Committee, Birendra Basnet, said that the airport here has good natural condition and can be operated throughout the year compared to airports like Janakpur, Rajbiraj and Biratnagar, as there is no fog during the rainy season.

According to the previously declared policy of the government to build one airport in each district and one helipad in each municipality, an airport capable of taking off and landing Jetstream aircraft of ATR 72 design is going to be built in Jogidaha, he said.

About 156.11 hectares of land has been acquired for the construction of 1,750 meters long and 30 meters wide runway, a terminal building with 200 meters long and 60 meters wide apron, staff building and two roads for taxi access.

Bandipur cable car construction crawling for years

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Feb. 9

The construction of the Bandipur cable car has progressed at a very slow pace, causing delays in its operational timeline. Originally scheduled to start operations four years ago, it has yet to be finalised.

When the former Chief Minister of Gandaki Province Prithvi Subba Gurung laid the foundation stone on July 20, 2018, it was expected that the cable car would be operational within 15 months.

Engineer Hari Datta Paudel, a member of the Board of Directors of Bandipur Cable Car and Tourism Limited, attributed the delay in operation to several factors, including forest route, the pandemic, and the delayed arrival of construction materials from abroad.

He added that the development of additional infrastructure such as five-star hotels and other structures was also postponed as the cable car's initial operation was delayed.

He informed that currently, the cable car is undergoing trial operations, with preparations underway for full operation starting from the upcoming Nepali New Year (2081 Baishakh, 1). Initially, only cable cars will be put into operation at the onset of the New Year. He also said that 90 per cent of the cable car's construction work has been completed.



PHOTO: AMAR RAJ NAHARKI/TRN

Bandipur in the picture where the cable car has to be constructed.

Kiran Pokharel, executive officer of the company, said that the company was currently in the process of acquiring international technology and safety quality test certificates, along with other necessary safety and completion-related certifications.

According to Cable Car Limited, the price of materials has risen by at least 25 per cent compared to earlier estimates, leading to increased costs. The construction cost of the cable car has now reached Rs 3.58 billion. Additionally, a 17-storey five-star hotel named "Queen Tower" is being constructed at the cable car's upper station.

The main feature of the hotel is its panoramic view from the 17th floor, offering stunning vistas of the surrounding areas of Bandipur. The cable car, capable of carrying 500 passengers per hour, will operate daily from 6 am to 11 pm, with various shifts throughout the day. The distance from Thuladhunga, Cable Car Chowk to Bandipur along the Prithvi Highway is about 1,700 metres.

Sadhutar becoming popular among visitors

BY RADHA LUITEL
Fidim, Feb. 9

Sadhutar, situated at an altitude of 8, 400 feet above sea level in Phidim Municipality-7 in Panchthar district, is an emerging tourist destination area. Nature enthusiasts can reach Sadhutar after a 3-kilometer journey off-road from Pauwabhanjyang, along the Ilam-Phidim road section of the Mechi Highway.

The reflection of the clear blue sky in the serene blue pond juxtaposed against the majestic backdrop of the Kanchenjunga and Kumbhakarna mountains adds beauty to the area. The picturesque pool of calm water and refreshing mountain air makes Satudar a beloved destination for tourists seeking leisure from the hectic schedule of city life.

Particularly during the monsoon season, Sadhutar bustles with visitors for picnics and recreation. The pond situated amidst the open space offers a mesmerising sight, with the reflection of the blue sky and the towering snow-capped mountains in the background.

These natural features attract several domestic tourists to Sadhutar. One local, Nimon Mukhia, said that especially on Saturdays and public holidays, people from various villages in Panchthar, as well as neighbouring districts of Tehrathum, Taplejung, Ilam, and Jhapa flock to the area.



PHOTO: RADHA LUITEL/TRN

Sadhutar in Panchthar district, is an emerging tourist destination.

Upon arrival, visitors are often occupied with capturing photos and videos of the scenic surroundings. Recently, there has been an increase in the presence of music video makers in the area as well.

Nearby destinations such as Pauwabhanjyang, Silauti, Sukepokhari and Lohakil also attract tourists. Prabhakar Mainali, who arrived from Atharai in Tehrathum, was drawn by the blooming rhododendrons in the nearby forests, the fir trees lining the area and the aesthetically constructed houses nearby.

There is a good arrangement for horse riding around the lake for the tourists who come to explore this area. Likewise, visitors arriving on motorcycles or bicycles often return after making a circuit around the pond.

Chinese company lashes back US claims

AP
Bangkok, Feb. 9

A Nasdaq-listed Chinese technology company that makes parts for self-driving vehicles is threatening to sue the U.S. government after it was included in a list of companies the Pentagon says have links to the Chinese military.

Hesai Technology's core product is LiDAR road sensing equipment, used in passenger and commercial vehicles, autonomous driving vehicles, delivery robots and other applications. It was among 17 companies the U.S. Department of Defense recently added to its list of companies it considers "Chinese military companies."

The revised list also includes Megvii, a Beijing-based artificial intelligence company and IDG Capital, a major private equity investment company with holdings in many Chinese technology companies, and major Chinese energy, telecoms and aviation companies. Its investors include U.S. pension funds and foundations.

Hesai's inclusion on the list came without any explanation and the company plans to file a lawsuit, Hesai CEO Yifan "David" Li said in a statement that described the move as "unjust, capricious and meritless."

"Hesai is not a military company. Hesai products are for civilian use only and have never been designed or validated for military use," he said.

Li did not give any details on the company's plans for legal action. The statement accused Hesai's critics of conducting a smear campaign against it for unfair commercial advantage.

In a statement issued last week, the company said its LiDARs were not designed to conform to military specifications. The U.S. Department of Commerce has designated them as not being suitable for any military application, it said. Hesai's stock price has fallen to about $4 from about $22 a year ago.

US administration has kept in place tariffs imposed by his predecessor Donald Trump after he launched a trade war against Beijing in 2018. Under Biden, the U.S. has further limited China's access to advanced U.S. technology, limited U.S. investments in strategically sensitive Chinese industries and expanded sanctions on leading Chinese companies like Huawei Technologies.

PepsiCo revenue slips in fourth quarter

AP
New York, Feb. 9

PepsiCo's profit rose in the fourth quarter thanks in part to lower charges, though revenue declined slightly. The food and beverage company also said Friday that it is boosting its annual dividend by 7% and plans to buy back about $1 billion of its shares.

For the three months ended Dec. 30, PepsiCo earned $1.3 billion, or 94 cents per share. That compares with $518 million, or 37 cents per share, a year earlier.

Excluding an impairment charge and other items, earnings were $1.78 per share. The performance topped the $1.72 per share analysts polled by Zacks Investment Research expected. Revenue slipped to $27.86 billion from $28 billion, missing Wall Street's estimate of $28.24 billion.

Pepsi has wrestled with higher prices and how to pass those costs along. It has raised prices by double-digit percentages for several quarters.

Global supermarket chain Carrefour said last month that it will stop selling PepsiCo products in its stores in France, Belgium, Spain and Italy due to price increases for popular items like Lay's potato chips, Quaker Oats, Lipton Iced Tea and its namesake soda.



PepsiCo said at the time that it would continue to engage in good faith with Carrefour to try to ensure that it products remained available. Its profits are up, though higher prices have dragged down sales as people trade down to cheaper brands. PepsiCo has been shrinking package sizes of some products in that environment.

PepsiCo Inc., based in Purchase, New York, has said price increases should ease and largely align with inflation, which has fallen considerably.

PepsiCo has pointed to higher costs for grain and cooking oil as it has raised prices. Costs for those food commodities surged following Russia's invasion in Ukraine but have since retreated on global markets from record highs in 2022. The company's stock fell more than 2% before the market open.

Bardibas is a place to study disasters: DPM Shrestha



PHOTO: TRN

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha handing over disaster management equipment to Bardibas Municipality in Mahottari.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bardibas, Feb. 9

Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha has handed over disaster management equipment to Bardibas Municipality in Mahottari, which is highly vulnerable to natural disasters.

On the occasion, DPM Shrestha handed over 28 items worth Rs. 1.86 million along with portable fire pumps provided by the National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA) to Mayor Prahlad Chhetri.

Addressing the 'Disaster Management Material Hand Over and Disaster Portal Localisation Programme' organised by the Authority in the administrative building of Bardibas Municipality on Friday, the DPM said that natural disasters are a nationwide problem.

He said that since Bardibas is at the meeting point of the Chure area and the Tarai, it is also a place to study natural disasters. These materials will help the municipality manage disasters and conduct training, he said.

"Careful management is required to reduce risk, and the three levels of government should give priority to cooperation and assistance to mitigated disasters," he said.

Bardibas Mayor Chhetri said that the citizens were suffering more due to the inability to manage the unorganised land, which is at risk of natural calamity in Bardibas

Mentioning the fact that the law has been an obstacle to managing the unorganised land, which is the ancestral home of thousands of families of Bardibas, the Mayor requested the DPM to delegate authority to the local level for its solution.

Chhetri said that for the people of Bardibas who are forced to face unimagined calamity every year, unorganised settlement had posed a further problem.

Anil Pokhrel, Chief Executive Officer of the Authority, said that Bardibas is at high risk of natural disasters. He said that since the remnants and signs of earthquakes in South Asia are found in the Bardibas area, the municipality should make a plan for disaster management keeping this fact in mind.

According to him, the Bardibas area is also the centre of earthquake risk in South Asia. The 1934 year earthquake caused a rift by pushing the land between Ratu and Patu in the north of Bardibas 10 metres up, and the place has become a research and study centre for geologists and students.

"Therefore, Bardibas should be developed as a centre for the study and training of natural disasters with the arrangement of 'smart sirens' in the district," said Pokhrel.

Two local levels hold joint executive meeting



PHOTO: TRN

Chairmen and vice-chairmen of Chichila Rural Municipality and Sabhapokhari Rural Municipality, Sankhuwasabha district after an agreement.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Sankhuwasabha, Feb. 9

Two local levels of Sankhuwasabha district-- Chichila Rural Municipality and Sabhapokhari Rural Municipality--organised a joint executive meeting and signed five different agreements for the development of their areas.

The meeting was organised on Thursday to jointly solve the common problems between the two municipalities.

In the meeting held at the office of Chichila Rural Municipality, the chairmen, vice-chairmen, executive members and chief administrative officers of both municipalities were present.

Chichila Rural Municipality Chairman Pasang Nurbu Sherpa, who also chaired the meeting, said that the joint meeting of the executive was held to share the construction of motorable bridges over the rivers between the two municipalities, physical infrastructure that concerns the two municipalities, natural resources belonging to the neighbouring municipalities and tourism promotion, among others.

Sherpa said that the joint meeting was also organised for cost reduction, maximum utilisation of resources and achieving effective services by sharing in the development works of both municipalities.

Bal Kumar Tamang, the spokesperson for Chichila Rural Municipality, said that five decisions were made at the meeting that would benefit both municipalities.

Tamang said that there was a need for a motorable bridge over the Orang River between Ward Number 2 of Sabapokhari and Ward Number 5 of Chichila Rural Municipality. The meeting also decided to take a collective initiative at the higher authorities to build the bridge at that place and if it had to be constructed in partnership, Chichila and Sabhapokhari would build it with equal investment.

Number of child marriages high in Jajarkot

BY BASUDEV SHARMA
Jajarkot, Feb. 9

Incidences of child marriages in the rural areas of Jajarkot district are on the rise. Recent data collected by both local authorities and donor agencies during earthquake relief distribution time revealed a significant surge in child marriage cases in the area.

Authorities were surprised to find that 60 per cent of the girls who were married were found holding their children. Even though child marriage is increasing in villages, the local level has not adopted any measures to control it. The local governments have remained silent without initiating public awareness activities to end the evil practice.

With no effort in place to reduce child marriage, girls are being forced into marriage as early as the age of 15. The trend is high among the poor, Dalits, underprivileged groups and school dropouts. The young girls marry believing that marriage will provide them with security in life due to their weak economic condition.

Deepak Nepali Badi from Bheri Municipality-1, Rawatgaun, said that girls were getting married at a young age due to their parents' poor financial condition, lack of funds to purchase educational materials and the inability to fulfil their desires.

Despite the government enforcing a minimum marriage age of 20 years, girls from rural areas are found to have two children by the age of 20. Moreover, children studying in grades 8 to 10 are being drawn into child marriages. Unfortunately, the local government has not taken any initiative to reduce this alarming trend of child marriage in the area, Badi said.

While Bheri Municipality, situated at the district headquarters, has made preparations to declare itself a child-friendly municipality in the upcoming year 2082, it has struggled to coordinate and collaborate with relevant agencies to conduct public awareness activities in the villages.

ANM Nirmata Rawat from the health post located in Jagatipur of Bheri Municipality-11 said that a majority of the women seeking post-delivery services at the health institution are teenagers with babies in their arms.

Pokhara-Muglin road extension in full swing

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Feb. 9

The expansion work of the eastern section of the Prithvi Highway is moving ahead in full swing, and around 25 kilometres roads have been blacktopped in either direction of the road section.

Shyam Kumar Yadav, the head of the Eastern Section, informed that a total of 24.5 kilometres of blacktopping has been completed so far, with 13.5 kilometres on the right side and 11 kilometres on the left side.

Yadav said, "We have accelerated the blacktopping process to minimise inconvenience for passengers, and over 45 per cent of the work has been completed." The contract for the eastern section was signed for Rs 6.21 billion, and work on this section has been ongoing since April 15, 2021, he informed.

The deadline for the completion of the 41.45 km section is April 2024. Rs. 150.13 million has been allocated to pay the compensation for removing 160 physical structures in the Dumre market area under the eastern section of the Prithvi Highway.



PHOTO: TRN

A glimpse of the expanded blacktopped road section of the Prithvi Highway.

A compensation of Rs. 60 million has been set for the removal of 75 physical structures in Damauli Bazaar, the district headquarters.

According to the Project Office, the majority of people of Dumre Bazaar has received compensation, and 80 per cent of demolition works have been completed so far.

Women's participation increases in daily wage work

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Humla, Feb. 9

The involvement of women in construction work has increased with the provision of equal daily wages for both genders working in the construction sector in the district.

Janaki Jaisi of Deukhuri in Kharpunath Rural Municipality-1 said that more women are attracted to the construction sector as gender-based discrimination in terms of wages has ended to a certain extent.

She said that due to the difference in wages, women were reluctant to work as construction labourers, but now they are getting equal pay which has made them enthusiastic to work in the construction sector.

Women have witnessed a surge in employment opportunities. Previously men were paid Rs. 1,000 and women were paid just Rs. 800 for the same work accomplished.

The women feel empowered by the elimination of inequality of wages for similar work. Matiu Rokaya from Simkot Rural Municipality-5 mentioned that women workers were attracted to construction work after they started getting equal pay.

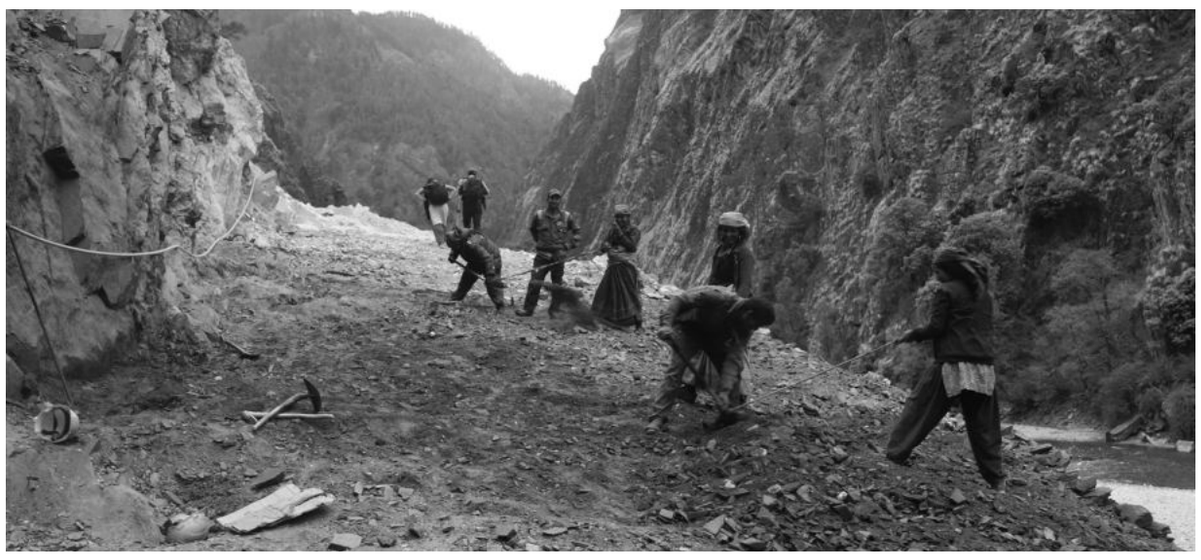


PHOTO: TRN

Local women of Humla are busy in road construction work.

Women labourers are earning Rs. 25,000 to Rs. 30,000 per month after the introduction of this policy.

Sunam Bahadur Lama, a construction businessman, said that female labourers too are equally efficient and hard-working. If we could add amenities like a separate toilet and other safety measures, it would be best for women.

321 victims of elephant attacks await compensations

RSS
Baniyani (Jhapa), Feb. 9

As many as 321 families fallen victim to wild elephant attacks in Jhapa district as of October 10 of the current fiscal year are awaiting compensation from the government.

The wild elephants wreaked havoc on people and properties in various places over different period in the ongoing fiscal year 2023/24.

The damages on properties and crops estimated to be over Rs 5.8 million have been sought by the local authority from the concerned ministry as compensation, said Division Forest Office, Jhapa's Forest Officer Rishiram Parajuli.

The compensation amount includes for the one deceased's family, loss of cattle and crops, Forest Officer Parajuli shared. Process is ongoing to claim the compensation for the 194 victims' families including four killed by wild elephant attacks since October 19 last year to till date, he said.

> Process is ongoing to claim the compensation for the 194 victims' families including four killed by wild elephant attacks since October 19 last year to till date.

Apart from the pain of losing their family member or bearing the loss on crops and properties, delays in receiving compensation have further added to the woe of the victims and their families, according to the staffers at the Division Forest Office.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

People may hear your words, but they feel your attitude.
-- John C. Maxwell

Bind Leadership To Constitutional Ideals

Dev Raj Dahal



Nepal's better future can be shaped by orienting all actors of society to value-frame and creating shared stake in nation building. This entails national leadership to set a balance between the sensible values of the nation's independent past and daily life of Nepalis consumed by survival imperative and between their sovereignty and a common identity that democracy offers for both. One critical challenge is how Nepali constitution emerged as a compromise document of NC, CPN-UML and CPM- Maoist Centre can imbibe the spirit of constitutionalism. The other is how the leadership can democratise decision centres to solve national problems by flair, know-how and policy. The sub-optimal progress in this area conditions the nation's vexed future.

Still, the other challenge is how to protect Nepali leaders from each other competing for drawn out rotational power and the public's due diligence against their seductive rule. The vital conditions such as ecological balance, social capital and economic resilience are wearing thin. In this context, only a sense of Nepalis' loyalty to the state and interactions among them in a normative frame can shape a decent conduct away from the paranoid politics of reaction and counter-action, not worthy action of fostering entrepreneurial spirit able to reconcile freedom, justice and order and transcend leaders' mental monoculture that stuck them in a heap of national problems.

Just distribution

Modern democratic rule supposes that people do not have to be responsible for what they have not done but are affected by leaders' verbal pedantry and impulsive action. The popular sovereignty allows them to challenge them even if a sense of fear of removal from power aligns them to defend the long period of stasis exhausting the prospects of transformational change. By correctly managing the riveting vision crystallised into the constitution Nepali leaders can refresh hope of people and ease production, exchange and just distribution of public goods in the future without stultifying political life. Beyond their own passion of power lust, they have promised Nepalis a good life in the constitution and party statutes and social transformation that obliges thinking in generational terms. They are the shapers of political culture, therefore, must abjure from vengefulness that animates instinct against rationality and curative power.

A leadership in command of state power without wisdom, skill and ability can harm public life. Its habitual craze of ego-inflation cannot tap the nation's vast natural potential and centripetal forces of the society - family, community, cultural industries, public institutions, business and civil society—averring nation building. Their timely learning from global experience and crafting apt public policies to respond to Nepalis needs and rights can shepherd the nation in the right rhythm. A leadership upholding constitutional ideals is likely to choose the best option, often seeking to advance sublime public order, realising democratic spirit and renouncing politics-business-bureaucracy racketeering for a pact of domination, not the democratisation of social and economic democratisation of political life.

The intergenerational transmission of knowledge for continuity and change of political life and apt dispensation of media and educational institutions to train those who will bear the knowledge in the future are, therefore, vital to escape from habit driven, imitative politics governed by half-conscious rule of law. What gives Nepalis a sense of optimism is the values of inclusion, proportional representation, affirmative action and social security in the body politik. It has eased the structural transformation in many areas -- Dalit, women, minorities, bonded labour, and marginalised people -- both necessary and possible. Under its impact a new kind of relationship among politics, power, law, knowledge and identity is unfolding.

What is still desirable is to manage and sustain the torch of tolerance so that a modicum of equilibrium between the state and social power is nurtured and the civic capacities of Nepalis are utilised for strengthening local self-governance in entrepreneurship, innovation, social discipline and impartial delivery of goods and services. Nepali leaders have to beat the shortfall of national self-determination by reducing external dependence on power, resources, legitimacy and geopolitics and internal drain of resources by despising grand scale stealing of public money that goes beyond public morality and integrity. The swelling budget and trade deficits, immoral and unpayable debt amassed by them for future citizens and piling of enormous vices in the nation may plug the nation's future in desolation forcing the youth to leave the nation en masse or think about unknown alternatives.

The moribund indicators of progress mark the betrayal of their future. Rebuilding their future requires investing in a range of causes including productive activities, livelihood, education, skill, health and income. Alleviating poverty and creating job opportunities in Nepal alone can leave this condition to the footnote of history. But a leviathan shackled by leader-oriented political parties and centralised bureaucracy cannot attain these goals and uphold principles of subsidiarity as both have pyramidal centralised structures disconnected from Nepalis demos and their instant feedback. Authoritarianism and economic decline feed off each other in a vicious way abating the moral and material spring of democracy. The infinite regress of the economy marks the rise of religious sentiments and emotional moments in the nation writhing an anti-incumbent twist and turn.

The praxis of transparency and accountability is, therefore, crucial for the consolidation of democracy, not just action and reflection on the torpor of the establishment. The howl of popular frustration is brimming over the overproduction of political elites, Nepalis can ill-afford to subsidise for long while funding them through conditionalised aid can clip them into a geopolitical loop and stifle national imagination and national self-determination. A consistency exists in patriarchal Nepali leaders preaching unattainable political sermons and people's restless behaviour unable to adjust to democratic life. One way to proceed with structural reforms calls for a sustained engagement of youths in the public life of the nation rather than compelling them to emigrate abroad in search of jobs.

> If the social upheavals of various sorts continue to shoot up and institutional integrity cannot cope with them, weak Nepal cannot carry both constitutional and international duties.

The other one is reforming the social studies and humanities courses in education infusing in youth an ability to reflect on Nepali condition and bear responsibility to uplift it rather than succumb to the stimuli of a heartless global market machine. It spawns civic projects and civic lessons, introduction of participatory style in learning, turning youths into autonomous learners thus enabling them to cope with the workplace demands and building productive political life. Still, another would be creating linkages of teaching with productive activities in the community, by introducing group collaboration and amassing the hard lessons of life-experience. These are the core tasks to speed up progress and leverage national wisdom to multi-civilisation order.

The empowerment process of marginalised youths requires the institutionalisation of social transformation. It means creation of an enabling environment through proper ecological, economic and social policies, elimination of all forms of discrimination, protection of their rights, reasonable access to decision making, strengthening institutional support and legal machinery and forging state institutions' partnership with business, communities and civil society to capacitate their ability to tame rent-seeking profligacy and pilfering of public resources. Dependence of people on external agencies undermines their choice beyond the rite of rationalisation. Weak sovereignty in the nation means democratic fragility and lure of Nepalis to many poles of market power increasingly aligned with changing geopolitical patterns.

Only sovereign Nepalis can make effective legitimacy and create leaders' authority to rule as per public and national interests. Election of leaders is vital for legitimacy but it does not guarantee their better performance unless they have the will and wisdom to pool resources to resolve the functional challenges and improve the quality of life of people. Social inclusiveness adopted by the constitution is good civic virtue but eroding material and institutional basis to meaningfully realise it cannot ignite faith, feeling and foresight about the quality of democratic life. The sharp rise of anomic and anarchic forces in Nepal is the result of growing discontentment of undelivered promises, detachment of mainstream leaders from ordinary folk and indulgence in blame shifting political culture arising out of aspiration, insatiability and envy, not fully achievement-oriented one.

These forces want to relieve the leadership for life of their duties for their ineptitude and flawed action on premature de-agrarianisaiton, de-industrialisation and financialisation of the national political economy which have combined to rip Nepali society's delicate fabric and drained social capital upon which sound political life can be pursued. Corruption-fed, import-driven, remittance and debt dependent economies cannot offer viable options for the nation's stable democratic life. The multi-cultural society can have enduring peace, justice and prosperity if each group of people, even the micro minority has proper voice, visibility and productive life.

If the social upheavals of various sorts continue to shoot up and institutional integrity cannot cope with them, weak Nepal cannot carry both constitutional and international duties. The peevish politics of Nepal hardly cares about the virtues of merit and novelty essential to steer law, admin, politics, economy and international relations for the nation's stable political life. The communication revolution is improving consciousness, the stock of knowledge and skills of Nepali youths. But they are less welcomed into the national polity and willingly offered the space that is theirs by constitutional and inter-generational right. Propelling them to leave the nation for abroad to eke out their livelihood is draining the social energy, productive forces of society, the catalyst of change agents and the nation's future though they are the sources and backbone of the national economy.

Judicious public action

The government's investment in human capital should be shored up through the cooperation of private sectors and civil society. It can improve the contents of functional education and skill to match with the new economy, health and employment conditions, enabling youths to participate in democratic political life. A number of civil societies have become breeding grounds of aspirations. It can help the co-equal people to improve the public understanding of governmental policies. Their newsletters, seminars, trainings and workshops, press news, protests against harmful policies, internet sites, curricular materials for Dalits, children, women's empowerment, trade unions, etc. can bear a democratising effect on a project scale, not engaging in the broader public space of deliberation, process refinement and judicious public action.

Many of them lack the ability to encourage critical thinking and adoption of native intellectual tradition, values of human rights and dignity which are essential to the transformation of rural Nepal. Retention and mobilization of youths for political and social responsibility can contribute enormously to the dawn of inter-group trust and translating the constitutional vision of egalitarian society through a synergy of the diverse economies into a reality. It can boost up the nation out of the morass of sterility to reasonable prosperity defined by shared rule of sane political life.

(Former Reader at the Department of Political Science, TU, Dahal writes on political and social issues.)

Teramocs: A Two-Faced Mystery

ANUPAM BHATTARAI

In the ever-changing world of telecommunications, fraud prevention and flawless connection depend heavily on effective traffic management and control. Ensuring the security and integrity of telecommunications networks is crucial in an era where digital communication predominates. With the deployment of the Telecommunications Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System, (Teramocs), Nepal gets going in this endeavor. This state-of-the-art technology opens up a Pandora's Box of insights and control mechanisms that might completely transform the nation's telecoms sector. Teramocs is a cutting-edge system for tracking, evaluating, and managing network traffic. Because the system runs in real-time, any suspect or illegal activity may be quickly detected and dealt with. Its main goals are to maximise the effectiveness of communications services, prevent fraud, and maintain the integrity of the network.

Teramocs tracks telecommunications traffic in real-time using sophisticated algorithms and monitoring technologies, which enables authorities to quickly identify suspicious activity and abnormalities. Teramocs can detect possible fraud cases, including SIM box fraud, foreign income fraud, and subscription fraud, by examining trends and abnormalities in call traffic. Authorities are able to respond quickly to stop financial losses and preserve the integrity of the telecom network thanks to this proactive strategy. It processes enormous volumes of telecom data while maintaining the privacy and security of sensitive information by using secure data analytics techniques.

Teramocs produces reports and warnings that may be customised according to pre-established criteria. This allows regulatory agencies and telecom companies to keep an eye on critical performance metrics and react quickly to any new risks or anomalies. It functions as a cooperative platform that enables the exchange of information and synchronisation between law enforcement, regulatory bodies, and telecom companies. Telecom operators can more efficiently allocate their resources when they use Teramocs. Improved service quality is the outcome of the system's ability to prioritise network traffic, identify any bottlenecks, and allocate resources efficiently. Teramocs presents a paradox as well as a solution, offering obstacles that must be carefully considered while also revealing the secrets of fraud control.

The telecom industry in Nepal can benefit greatly from its deployment. Teramocs has increased customer trust in telecommunications services by strengthening security protocols and reducing fraudulent activity. Additionally, Teramocs' proactive strategy has protected regulatory agencies' and telecom companies' profits, bolstering the nation's general economic stability. Critics argue that concepts like criminality, national interest, and sovereignty are defined broadly and at the discretion of government authorities. The government has produced the Bill to Amend and Unify the Laws Related to Telecommunications, 2079 in order to fully adopt Teramocs technology. In the event that the Parliament passes this Bill in its current form, people's rights to privacy and freedom will be violated. The administration pushed to use the NTA to deploy this technology, which prevented the Bill from moving ahead. 'By having direct access to the service provider's system, it will be feasible to record the talks of the necessary individuals and install a mechanism utilising appropriate technology,' reads section 77 of the Bill.

Teramocs also presents a paradoxical challenge – a complexity resulting from the intricate structure of telecommunications security. The very characteristics of Teramocs that make it an effective deterrent to fraud also add to the complexity of running and maintaining such an advanced system. By offering automatic warnings, fraud detection, and real-time surveillance, Teramocs strengthens security measures. This feature is consistent with the promise of improved security, since it gives authorities the ability to anticipate attacks and take preventative action. A complex web of requirements that need ongoing attention and resources is created by the requirement for updates, adaptable responses to new threats, and coordination among stakeholders.

In Nepal, Teramocs represents a contradiction, serving as a source of complexity as well as a potentially useful remedy for telecom security. In order to overcome this paradox, stakeholders must take a calculated and cooperative approach, proactively addressing obstacles and fully using Teramocs. Nepal must recognise its dual nature as it follows the route of telecom security in order to make sure that the Pandora's Box it unlocks continues to be a force for good in the nation's digital environment.

Health Risks Of Weight Enhancing Injection In Goats

Krishna Prasad Acharya



Sonu Adhikari



Medroxyprogesterone acetate (MPA) aka 'Sangini Sui' is a long-acting female contraceptive designed for use in women for birth control, and is not recommended for use in animals. Nowadays, Nepali farmers have rampantly used this female contraceptive injection as a weight booster in the male goat. This unconventional application of MPA as a growth promoter has brought debates owing to its detrimental effects on animal health, human health, and the environment. Although MPA is used for estrus synchronization in female goat, this practice in male goats could be detrimental. This article aims to explore the harmful consequences of this practice in sectors such as animal health, human health, and the environment arguing that the side effects of 'Sangini Sui' far outweigh the potential benefits to the farmers.

The 'Sangini Sui' is a popular injectable contraceptive originally intended for use in women, which contains a synthetic form of human progesterone. A research by Lehloenya and his colleagues in South Africa found an increase in weight after estrus synchronisation of the Boer and Nguni female Goat with MPA injection (https://doi.org/10.1016/j.smallrumres.2004.05.004). This change in the weight of male goats motivated farmers to use this injection as a growth promoter. This increased weight is supposed to enhance the market value. This trend of the use of MPA as a growth promoter has gained momentum among Nepali farmers in the absence of stringent scientific and regulatory oversights.

> The practice of using MPA in male goats is a problematic and serious issue given its adverse effects on animal and human health.

An illusion of prosperity

The proponents of the use of MPA as a growth promoter argue that 'Sangini Sui' provides economic benefits to farmers by enhancing their returns through weight gains. The weight gain should not overshadow the potentially harmful future consequences on animal health, human health, and the environment. One of the most conspicuous issues regarding the rampant use of 'Sangini Sui' as a growth promoter in male goats is the non-scientific approach to authenticate its efficacy and safety. Similarly, frequent use and long-term effects on animal health and its residual effects in meat have not been studied yet, thereby leaving farmers and consumers in the dark about the potential risks they are undertaking. However, it is highly likely that the hormonal residue from the injected animals can leach into the soil, potentially contaminating groundwater sources and affecting other species in the ecosystem.

Although the practice of using 'Sangini Sui' may enhance the temporary weight gain in animals, it is imperative to consider the issues of the welfare of the animals involved. Injecting MPA into male goats not only affects the hormonal imbalance in the goat but also causes potential effects altering their physiological behaviour along with reproductive issues and disruption in the overall health. The use of MPA disrupts the blood hormonal equilibrium in the male goats suppressing male hormones such as testosterone, leading to harmful physiological events. For instance, a decrease in libido, and impaired reproductive function might be noticed. And, in some cases, it might trigger some harmful effects on the whole endocrine system. Apart from the beneficial effects of weight gain, there could be untoward long-term consequences in male goats thereby diminishing the success of breeding. This may adversely affect the sustainability of goat production in Nepal.

Harmful effects

The potentially harmful effects of 'Sangini Sui' extend beyond animal health to humans particularly, farmers who depend on livestock farming for subsistence. At present, 'Sangini Sui' as a weight booster in male goats might create a false sense of success for the farmer. However, long-term consequences with an adverse effect on animal health and productivity might lead to financial losses to the farmers who depend on livestock for their livelihood. In addition, the presence of hormone residues in meat and dairy products poses a risk to human health; however, such potential harmful effects are yet to be fully understood. Research have highlighted the adverse effects on human health such as carcinogenesis, endometrial hyperplasia, mammary hyperplasia, and reproductive toxicity through ingestion of residual hormone through meat and milk.

Thus, in a nutshell, the practice of using MPA in male goats is a problematic and serious issue given its adverse effects on animal and human health. Although it may provide short-term economic benefits, the potential long-term effects on animal health, human health, animal welfare, and the environment should not be ignored. Moreover, the absence of any rigorous scientific validations and regulatory oversights may worsen health hazards with this practice. All relevant stakeholders such as the policymakers, and farmers must aim towards sustainable goat farming rather than imposing any shortcut remedies towards the wrong practices that might impact animal health, human health, and the whole ecosystem.

(Acharya is a Veterinary officer at the Department of Livestock Services and Adhikari is a registered veterinary doctor under the Nepal veterinary council.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

February 10, 1974

Travellers' Cheques

Kathmandu, Feb. 9: Kathmandu banking office of Nepal bank issued travellers' cheque for 599180 U.S. dollars from the month of Baisakh to Aswin of the current financial year, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

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Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Revive Nepal's Garment Sector

This is in reference to the news story titled "*Nepal to showcase ready-made garments in US fashion fair*" this daily published on Feb. 9.

The fair is considered as the most comprehensive fashion marketplace in the US to show apparel, footwear, accessories and sourcing resources from across the world.

Showcasing such Nepali products in the US is crucial, for it is one of their biggest markets in the world.

In 2001/02, the country used to buy Nepali garments worth USD 400 million and the industry employed tens of thousands of people; now, sadly, it's a fraction of that.

If concrete measures are taken, the sector is well-placed to be revived to its former glory.

The growing supply of abundant electricity coupled with the cheap labour force can be instrumental in this effort.

Already, there are dozens of home-grown garment industries producing quality apparel and winning over a growing number of people to get them to buy their products.



This huge potential needs to be harnessed.

Dinesh Karmacharya
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A wealthy man died and went to heaven. He was met at the Pearly Gates by Saint Peter who led him down the streets of gold. They passed mansion after mansion until they came to the very end of the street. Saint Peter stopped the rich man in front of a little shack."This belongs to you," said Saint Peter. "Why do I get this ugly thing when there are so many mansions I could live in?" the man demanded. "We did the best we could with the money you sent us!" Saint Peter replied.

Palestinian aid agency UNRWA can't be replaced: UN chief

AFP
New York, Feb. 9

United Nations Secretary-General Antonio Guterres on Thursday warned that the organisation's Palestinian refugee agency UNRWA cannot be replaced, even as it faces criticism and donor pullout after 12 staffers were accused by Israel of involvement in the Hamas-led October 7 attacks.

Fears over conditions throughout Gaza are mounting as more than 1 million Palestinians seek shelter in Rafah, where Israel is intensifying bombardment in preparation for a possible ground operation.

UNRWA chief Philippe Lazzarini said in a separate statement Thursday that hundreds of thousands of lives are at risk in north and central Gaza because of a lack of food.

Hundreds of thousands of people's lives are at risk in north and central Gaza because of a lack of food, the UN agency for Palestinian refugees (UNRWA) warned on Thursday.

UNRWA chief Philippe Lazzarini said the last time the agency was allowed to deliver supplies to the area was more than two weeks ago on January 23.

Other agencies providing humanitarian aid also reported blocks on getting relief into the Palestinian territory, which has been bombarded by Israel since Hamas's deadly attack on October 7.

"Since the beginning of the year, half of our aid mission requests to the north were denied," Lazzarini wrote on X, formerly Twitter.



Photo: AFP

People walk past tents housing displaced Palestinians pitched along a crowded main street in Rafah in the southern Gaza Strip on February 8, 2024.

Meanwhile, US Secretary of State Antony Blinken on Wednesday said a ceasefire deal between Israel and Hamas is still possible after Israeli Prime Minister Binyamin Netanyahu earlier rejected Hamas's conditions as "delusional".

"While there are some clear non-starters in Hamas's response, we do think it creates space for agreement to be reached, and we will work at that relentlessly," Blinken told reporters in Tel Aviv hours after meeting with Netanyahu. Read our blog to see how the day's events unfolded.

Independent candidates backed by ex-PM Khan's lead Pakistan election

AP
Pakistan, Feb. 9

Independent candidates backed by imprisoned former Prime Minister Imran Khan were leading Pakistan's national election results Friday, a day after sporadic violence, allegations of a preordained outcome and a cellphone service shutdown overshadowed the vote.

Of the 122 National Assembly results announced by the country's election oversight body after an hour-long delay, candidates backed by Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party have won 49 seats.

It's a surprise given claims by the imprisoned Khan, his supporters and a national rights body of pre-poll rigging and manipulation.

The Pakistan Muslim League party of three-time former Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif had 39 seats, while the Pakistan People's Party of political dynasty scion Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari had 30. All results were expected by Friday night.

If no party wins an outright majority, the one with the most seats can try to form a coalition government. Pakistan's deeply divided political climate, however, is unlikely to produce a coalition pulling together for the betterment of the country, which is grappling with high inflation, year-round energy outages, and militant attacks.

Khan, a former cricketer turned politician with a significant grassroots following, was disqualified from running in Thursday's election because of criminal convictions he contends were

It's a surprise given claims by the imprisoned Khan, his supporters and a national rights body of pre-poll rigging and manipulation.

politically motivated. He was imprisoned in the run-up to the election.

His party's candidates ran as independents after the Supreme Court and Election Commission said they couldn't use the party symbol — a cricket bat. In Pakistan, parties use symbols to help illiterate voters find them on the ballots. PTI couldn't hold rallies or open campaign offices, and its online events were blocked, steps it contended were unfair.

The chief election commissioner previously said the results would be communicated to the oversight body by early Friday and released to the public after that. But it started happening only at midday. The Interior Ministry attributed the delay to a "lack of connectivity" resulting from security precautions.

Many Pakistani news channels reported that independent candidates backed by Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf, or PTI, were giving the other big parties, led by Sharif and Bhutto-Zardari, the son of the assassinated former Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto, a run for their money by striding ahead in dozens of constituencies.

Finns will choose new president on Sunday



Photo: AP

Leaders after the early vote results, National Coalition Party candidate Alexander Stubb, right, and Social Movement candidate Pekka Haavisto stand during the Presidential election event, at the Helsinki City Hall, in Helsinki, Finland, Sunday, Jan. 28, 2024.

AP
Helsinki, Feb. 9

Finns on Sunday will choose either of two experienced politicians to be their next head of state, whose main task will be to steer the Nordic country's foreign and security policy now that it is a member of NATO, following Russia's invasion of Ukraine.

Ex-Prime Minister Alexander Stubb, 55, on the centre right, and former foreign Minister Pekka Haavisto, 65, from the green left, largely agree on Finland's foreign policy and security priorities. These include maintaining a hard line toward Moscow and Russia's current leadership, strengthening security ties with Washington, and the need to help Ukraine both militarily and at a civilian level.

In the last days of campaigning, however, tiny differences in style and approach between the candidates have emerged.

"After the exceptionally polite campaigning of the first round, there has been a bit more confrontation" between the two men vying for the post, said Teivo Teivainen, professor of world politics at the University of Helsinki.

Stubb and Haavisto differ in their stance on the hypothetical question of whether Finland, a NATO newcomer, would allow the transportation of the alliance's nuclear weapons through its territory.

"Stubb has a more positive attitude in bringing in nuclear weapons into Finland's territory," Teivainen said. "This reflects his slightly more positive line towards NATO integration and the United States."

Unlike in most European countries, the president of Finland holds executive power in formulating foreign and security policy together with the government, especially concerning countries outside the European Union such as the United States, Russia and China.

The head of state also commands the military, particularly important in Europe's current security environment and the changed geopolitical situation of Finland, which joined NATO in April 2023 in the aftermath of Russia's attack on Ukraine a year earlier.

North Korea welcomes Russian tourists

AP
North Korea, Feb. 9

A group of Russian tourists headed to North Korea from Vladivostok airport in Russia's Far East on Friday, likely the first foreign travellers from any country to enter the isolated state since the pandemic.

The tour underscores deepening cooperation between Moscow and Pyongyang, following a meeting last September between North Korean leader Kim Jong Un and Russian President Vladimir Putin at a cosmodrome in Russia's Far East.

Many Russians now struggle to travel to Europe and the United States because of sanctions applied to Russia after its invasion of Ukraine. In October, Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov said he would recommend North Korea as a vacation destination.

South Korea's government said it has no record of North Korean state media reporting on tourists entering the country since the pandemic.

The tour group will visit the capital Pyongyang and will then go skiing, Inna Mukhina, the general director of the Vostok Intur agency, which is running the tour, told The Associated Press. Vladivostok airport's online timetable shows an Air Koryo plane took off for Pyongyang at 1.39 p.m. local time Friday.



Photo: AP

A group of Russian tourists, likely the first foreign travellers from any country to enter North Korea since the pandemic arrive at the Pyongyang International Airport in Pyongyang, North Korea, Friday, Feb. 9, 2024.

There are "lots" of people who wanted to come on the tour to North Korea, Mukhina, the tour operator, said, adding that the group contains travellers from places across Russia including Moscow and St. Petersburg as well as the Russian exclave of Kaliningrad, sandwiched in between Poland and Lithuania.

The group also includes children who study skiing at a Russian school that aims to create Olympic champions, she said.

The Russians' reasons for visiting North Korea vary, Mukhina said, suggesting some people are interested in the opportunity to visit a closed country, while others are more interested in skiing and snowboarding.

"We love skiing," Galina Polevshchikova told the AP at Vladivostok airport shortly before getting on the flight to Pyongyang. "I really want to go there because it's probably the most closed place where you have the opportunity to do this," she said.

PRISM

Baby rhino ventures outside of zoo

Oregon: A baby rhino at the Oregon Zoo went outside for the first time, and officials revealed the calf is a boy.

The eastern black rhino calf, born Dec. 4, celebrated turning 2 months old during his first trip outside, accompanied by his mother, Jozi, the zoo announced.

The zoo said officials have not decided on a name for the "tiny tank" and they are accepting suggestions from the public.

Eastern black rhinos are critically endangered, and the calf's birth was welcomed as a crucial step in conservation for the Africa-native species.

Birds take up residence inside Walmart

Saskatchewan: Shoppers at a Walmart store in Saskatchewan were surprised to discover the store has some new residents -- birds.

The birds have been flying around in recent days inside the Preston Crossing Walmart in Saskatoon.

Jan Shadick, executive director with Living Sky Wildlife Rehabilitation, said the birds likely aren't inside the store by accident.

"When it's minus 50 out in Saskatchewan they're not crazy, they're going to be looking for somewhere warm," Shadick told CTV News.

Shadick said the best thing to do for the birds is to ignore them, as they would be difficult to evict. She said people should only be concerned if they spot the birds landing on the floor. "They might be starting to get sick or more likely just be really hungry and weak," Shadick said.

A Walmart in Texas previously made headlines in 2016 when hundreds of blackbirds descended on the parking lot.

(AP)

Patients, doctors push back against cancer drug side effects

AP
New York, Feb. 9

For cancer patients, the harsh side effects of powerful drugs have long been the trade-off for living longer. Now, patients and doctors are questioning whether all that suffering is necessary.

They've ignited a movement to radically change how new cancer drugs are tested, with the U.S. Food and Drug Administration urging drugmakers to do a better job at finding the lowest effective dose, even if it takes more time.

Advances in treatment mean millions of people are surviving for years with incurable cancers. Jill Feldman, 54, of Deerfield, Illinois, has lived 15 years with lung cancer, thanks to that progress. Her parents both died of lung cancer months after their diagnoses.

But her cancer drug causes joint pain, fatigue and mouth sores that make eating and drinking painful.



Photo: AP

Cancer patients and doctors have ignited a movement to radically change how new cancer drugs are tested to make them more tolerable.

"If you drink something that's too hot, you really burn your mouth. That's how my mouth feels 24/7," Feldman said.

She has lowered the dose with her doctor's blessing but she wants drugmakers to study lower doses early in the research process.

"No one should have to endure avoidable harmful effects of treatment," she said.

Unlike in other diseases, cancer drug development has focused on finding what's called the "maximum tolerated dose." To speed testing of chemotherapy drugs, researchers ramp up the dosage in a few people in early studies to determine the highest possible dose patients can tolerate.

That "more is better" philosophy works for chemotherapy, but not necessarily for newer cancer drugs — like the one Feldman takes — which are more targeted and work differently.

Chemotherapy is like a battering ram where aggressive strikes are a good strategy.

But newer cancer drugs are more like having a front door key. They target a mutation that drives cancer cell growth, for example, or rev up the body's immune system to join the fight.

"You might only need a low dose to turn off that cancer driver," said Dr. Lillian Siu, who leads cancer drug development at the Princess Margaret Cancer Center in Toronto. "If you can get the same bang for your buck, why go higher?"

Through a program called Project Optimus, the FDA is pushing drugmakers to include more patients in early dose-finding trials to get better data on when lower doses can work. A key motivation for the project was "the growing calls from patients and advocates that cancer drugs be more tolerable," said FDA spokesperson Chanapa Tantibanchachai in an email.

Many of the new cancers drugs were developed using the old strategy. That leads to problems when patients skip doses or stop taking the drugs because of side effects.

Some dose recommendations have been officially lowered after the drugs were approved. Other dose-lowering happens one patient at a time. Nearly half of patients in late-stage trials of 28 targeted therapy drugs needed to have their doses lowered, according to one study.

"We were pushing the dose as high as we could go," said Dr. Patricia LoRusso, who leads drug discovery at Yale Cancer Center. "You get side effects and then you have to stop the drug to recover from the side effects and the tumor can grow."

TODAY IN HISTORY

1923 – Texas Tech University is founded as Texas Technological College in Lubbock, Texas.
1939 – Spanish Civil War: The Nationalists conclude their conquest of Catalonia and seal the border with France.
1940 – The Soviet Union begins mass deportations of Polish citizens from occupied eastern Poland to Siberia.
1967 – The 25th Amendment to the United States Constitution is ratified.
2013 – Thirty-six people are killed and 39 others are injured in a stampede in Allahabad, India, during the Kumbh Mela festival.
2021 – The traditional Carnival in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil is canceled for the first time because of the COVID-19 pandemic.

LHOSAR GREETINGS

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 10

President Ramchandra Paudel has extended his best wishes to all brothers and sisters at home and abroad for their happiness, peace and prosperity on the occasion of Sonam Lhosar festival of Tamang community.

In a message delivered today, President Paudel expressed his confidence that the festivals like Sonam Lhosar would help enhance good will, tolerance and fraternity among all the people in the Nepali society enriched with diversities in terms of castes, languages and cultures, thereby further consolidating the broader national unity.

The Sonam Lhosar is celebrated as the New Year of Tamang community. The community people offer prayers to their ancestors, nature and impart the message of Buddha as well as exchange mutual happiness among their kiths and kin.

MINISTER SHARMA INSISTS ON TIMELY COMPLETION OF PROJECTS

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

Minister for Communications and Information Technology, Rekha Sharma, has directed the chiefs of subordinate bodies to take initiation to complete the ongoing projects and programmes within the deadline.

During the half-yearly review of the fiscal year 2023-24 and in a meeting of ministry-level development issues resolution committee in the Ministry today, the Minister called upon all stakeholders to conduct self-assessments of the progress made so far and to exert concerted efforts to achieve the expected achievements from the ongoing endeavors.

She urged participants to work responsibly, discouraging the practice of diverting attention towards pointing out the shortcomings of others. "While reviews are encouraged, avoiding responsibility is not acceptable," she asserted.



PHOTO: RSS

Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha inaugurating e-visa, automated system and online payment services amid a programme at the Immigration Department in Kalikasthan, Kathmandu on Friday.

Second Nepal bird festival begins in Nawalpur

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Feb. 9

The second Nepal Bird Festival has begun in Kawasoti, in East Nawalparasi. The primary aim of this festival is to boost tourism by showcasing the region's diverse birdlife.

Manshant Ghimire, President of the Pokhara Bird Society, said that the festival was arranged to generate awareness of bird and wildlife conservation awareness among the rural communities.

Ghimire informed that the second bird festival was being held in Kawasoti Municipality-13 for three days, starting from February 9 to February 11, 2024. The event is aimed at safeguarding birds and their habitats, raising public awareness and providing livelihood opportunities for stakeholders.

The birds found in this region, including the spiny babbler, eagle, and kingfisher, have reached an endangered state. Conservationist Chungba Sherpa said that factors such as illegal bird hunting and trade, obstruction of flight paths, climate change, scarcity of safe food sources, and the escalating use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides in agriculture have contributed to the extinction of these bird species.

He said, "It is the responsibility of all of us to protect the endangered birds from illegal trade and poaching." Recently, bird tourism has emerged as a focal point of interest in Nepal. Since bird tourism tends to be more lucrative compared to other forms of tourism, it has the potential to bring in foreign currency, he added.

The three-day festival, jointly organised by the Jatayu Restaurant Management Committee and Bird Education Society, will feature various activities. These include bird watching, bird identification training, trail packages, a photo exhibition, a bird art competition, observation of vulture activities, jungle safaris, and cultural performances representing the Tharu, Musahar, and Bote communities, said DB Chaudhary, coordinator of Jatayu Restaurant.

The festival is being attended by representatives of 39 organisations working in the field of biodiversity, tour operators, locals and students from countries including India, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Malaysia, Hong Kong, Singapore, Philippines, Japan, Switzerland, USA, Ireland and Taiwan, Tikaram Giri said.

The programme also features bird and nature observation, a painting competition, local endangered games, and cultural songs and dances.

A total of 43 species of birds are considered rare globally, with 39 of them found around the Narayani River and Chitwan National Park.

Nepal boasts 894 bird species, with 565 species found around the Narayani River in Nawalpur and Chitwan National Park.

Maoist Centre starts discussion on statute draft

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

The Standing Committee of the CPN (Maoist Centre) has started deliberation on statute draft. During the standing committee meeting held at the headquarters of the CPN (Maoist Centre), Parisdanda, on Friday, coordinator of the of statute drafting taskforce and party Vice-Chairperson, Pampha Bhusal, gave a presentation on the main features of the statute, said Spokesperson Agni Sapkota.

General-Secretary Dev Prasad Gurung, Deputy General-Secretaries—Giriraj Mani Pokharel, Barsha Man Pun, and Janardan Sharma, Secretaries—Ganesh Saha and Ram Karki and Standing Committee member Shashi Shrestha put forth their views on the statute.

Most of the members who spoke on the statute stressed the provision of establishing social norms, values and ideologies as well as socialist thoughts in the statute. The leaders had expressed the views that party committees should be manageable and functional. The central committee should be of 151 members, she suggested.

Sapkota, however, shared that the issues raised during discussion would be sorted out from statute conference.

The standing committee would meet again on Saturday. The CPN (Maoist Centre) has called central committee meeting coming Sunday and Monday to discuss the statute. The statute convention of the party is scheduled for February 13-15.

Immigration Department launches e-visa, automated system

RSS
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

The Immigration Department launched e-visa, automated system and online payment on Friday. Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister Narayan Kaji Shrestha inaugurated the services amidst a programme at Immigration Department Office, Kalikasthan.

Director General at the Department, Rudra Singh Tamang, informed that new services would be available at Department Office from 8:00am to 8:00pm from February 13.

The Department, for now, has enforced 'electronic trial authorization', a preparatory work to implement e-visa. Under the trial authorization, any foreigner willing to apply for Nepali visa can fill up the online form and submit fee accordingly.

Similarly, all sorts of service fees and fines can be submitted via mobile banking and wallet service providers.

The service seekers can track the status of their application and payment online. The Department also provides information on it via email and SMS. The employees will facilitate communications with the customers having low digital literacy.

Director General Tamang informed that automated and online services were being put in place to ensure transparency, accountability and frugality in the entire immigration administration. He further shared that digital signature would be launched within this year. The Department also launched its new website on Friday.

90 % of roses for Valentine's Week imported

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

Sales of roses have soared at several flower shops in the Kathmandu Valley and other districts as Valentine's Week commenced on Wednesday with Rose Day. Roses are one of the best-selling flowers in the week leading to Valentine's Day.

Flower traders assumed that about 350,000 stems of roses would be sold during the Valentine's Day week. Of them, 315,000 stems of roses would be imported from India and the demand of the other 35,000 stems of roses will be fulfilled from domestic production.

Min Bahadur Tamang, President of Floriculture Association Nepal (FAN), said that of the total demand for roses, 90 per cent of roses will be imported from New Delhi India; the domestic produce meets only 10 per cent of the demand, he added.

Tamang said that 240,000 stems of roses are consumed in the Kathmandu Valley and the remaining 140,000 stems of roses are consumed in other cities of the country.

Before Valentine's Day, there is a practice of marking the seven days of the whole week with different names - Rose Day, Propose Day, Chocolate Day, Teddy Day, Promise Day, Hug Day and Kiss Day.

The demand for and import of roses is higher ahead of Valentine's Day than at other times. The demand for rose is likely to increase this year compared to the previous year. With the increasing demand for roses, the Floriculture Association Nepal (FAN) is importing 315,000 stems for this year's Valentine's Day week, said Tamang, president of FAN.

"Domestic production of rose has decreased due to the cold weather," he said. The demand for roses is high, especially in the Kathmandu Valley, about 210,000 stems of the rose will be traded in Kathmandu Valley during the week-long event.

Brazil police investigate ex-President Bolsonaro's top aides

AP
Rio De Janeiro, Feb. 9

Brazilian police on Thursday searched homes and offices of former President Jair Bolsonaro's top aides in an investigation alleging they plotted a coup and that the ex-president was aware of the plan, court documents showed.

The alleged plot in the event Bolsonaro lost the 2022 election involved having him sign a decree declaring the vote fraudulent to justify a possible military intervention and convene new elections. Though Bolsonaro did lose the election, the right-wing leader never issued the decree to set the final stage of the alleged plot into motion.

Bolsonaro was not himself a target of Thursday's searches, but like others was ordered to forfeit his passport, according to a decision by Supreme Court Justice Alexandre de Moraes made public Thursday.

Police said in a statement that they searched several homes and offices of suspects who "acted to attempt a coup d'etat" that would have kept Bolsonaro in power after his October 2022 election defeat to leftist leader Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva.

Police alleged the group had prepared to allege voting fraud "in order to enable and legitimize a military intervention."

Supreme Court documents authorizing the searches show that police claim that Filipe Martins, a special adviser, presented Bolsonaro a draft decree ahead of the election that included ordering the arrest of two Supreme Court justices, including Moraes, who presided over the election body overseeing the election.

Bolsonaro allegedly asked to have several items removed from the decree, while keeping a call for new elections and modifying the order to arrest only one of the Supreme Court justices — de Moraes. Bolsonaro also allegedly called a meeting with the heads of the armed forces to present the modified plan and get them to "adhere" to it.

The targets of Thursday's 33 searches included Martins, and Bolsonaro's 2022 running mate, Gen. Walter Braga Netto; a former adviser, Gen. Augusto Heleno; former Justice Minister Anderson Torres and the head of Bolsonaro's Liberal Party, Valdemar Costa Neto, the decision said.

Bolsonaro's lawyer, Fabio Wajngarten, said on X, formerly Twitter, that Bolsonaro would comply with the order to hand over his passport. A Bolsonaro aide among the search targets was with the former president at the time of the Thursday morning operation, Wajngarten said.

The aide was asked to return to Brazil's capital, Brasilia, to put Bolsonaro in compliance with an order not to have any contact with individuals under investigation, the lawyer said.

Carlos Melo, a political science professor at Insper University in Sao Paulo, said Thursday's revelations were a major turn of events for Bolsonaro.

"Until now, he could always say he didn't know about this," Melo said. But the content of the Supreme Court decision, a 135-page long document, suggests this is no longer the case, he said.

Koshi govt...

inking the five-point agreement.

On behalf of the provincial government, Coordinator of the talk team and Minister for Physical Infrastructure Development Kamal Prasad Jabegu, member and Minister for Tourism, Forest and Environment Ganesh Prasad Upreti and member secretary of the Ministry of Internal Affairs, Law Laxmi Prasad Paudel signed the agreement. Similarly, Dakendra Singh Thegim, Govinda Bahadur Angbuhang, Yubraj Rai, Bibash Rai, Lakpa Sherpa, Kumar Lingden, Padam Limbu, Arjun Jamneli Rai, Dumbar Lawati, Padam Jabegu and Chandra Kumar Chaudhary signed on behalf of the agitating party.

After the Koshi Province Assembly named the province 'Koshi' on March 1, 2023, agitating groups, which present themselves as Pahichanbadi are protesting against the province government showing their dissatisfaction over the nomenclature process.

They have been demanding that the province be renamed.

Earlier, the then Chief Minister Hikmat Kumar Karki's government held a formal dialogue with the Struggle Committee on June 19, 2023. However, due to government reshuffle and instability at that time, the talks could not continue.

One protester who was injured in a clash with police personnel during the protests in Biratnagar on March 19 last year died while undergoing treatment.

Democracy Day to be marked for...

According to the secretariat of the Prime Minister, the meeting on Friday decided to organise the main event of Democracy Day at the Army Pavilion in Kathmandu on February 19.

Likewise, the meeting requested to make arrangements for the production, operation and broadcasting of special dialogues, seminars, radio dramas and other public awareness programmes focusing on Democracy Day on February 19. It decided to ask the national-level print media to publish special issues/souvenirs on the occasion highlighting the multifaceted dimensions of democracy.

On the eve of Democracy Day, national flags of the prescribed size will be placed on the roofs, verandas and premises of all government agencies, institutions, associations and offices, and in the evening, the areas such as Mandala, Durbar Square and homes will be illuminated.

Similarly, the government has decided to conduct a blood donation programme in all districts with the help of government and non-government organisations. Distribution of suitable educational and sports materials to schools where students with different abilities study is also planned at the district level.

On Democracy Day, the Nepali Army will play the bugle from Dharahara, offer nine cannons of gun salute in the morning from Army Pavilion, Tundikhel, display cannons and guns, and parade.

The meeting also asked for the presence of elected representatives, civil servants, security personnel, public and community organisations and officials of educational and academic institutions, eminent personalities of civil society and the general public in Tundikhel on the main day of celebration.

The meeting has decided to broadcast awareness-generating songs on the occasion of Democracy Day from Radio Nepal and Nepal Television and to request other radio, FM and television stations to broadcast them as well.

The meeting also approved the programmes for the Nepali embassies, diplomatic missions and consulates abroad. The meeting has suggested decorating the roof, balcony and premises of Nepali embassies, diplomatic missions and consulates abroad with the national flag of the prescribed size and lighting the lamp in the evening.

The meeting requested for similar celebrations at the province, district and local levels. It said that the provinces will mark the day by forming the National Democracy Day Programme Organising Committee under the coordination of the Chief Ministers, districts will mark it by forming the National Democracy Day Programme Organising Committee under the district coordination committee chairs and local levels will mark it by forming a similar committee under local level heads.

32 % wholesale, retail...

average trade margin in the reference year is 18.53 per cent. The motor and repair recorded the highest trade margin at 24.02 per cent followed by retail trade at 18.28 per cent.

The wholesale trade received the lowest trade margin at 13.01 per cent among the three trade categories.

It showed that the average trade margin percentage was the highest in Gandaki followed by Karnali and Madhes Province which were 20.09 per cent, 19.9 per cent and 19.34 per cent respectively. Koshi Province has the lowest average trade margin at 16.77 per cent.

The data showed that there was a significant difference among the provinces in the trade margin of motor trade and repair.

Highest operating cost per establishment in Bagmati Province

The report further showed that the average annual operating cost per establishment was Rs. 264,373 in the reference year.

Among the provinces, Bagmati Province had the highest average annual operating cost per establishment at Rs. 470,340 followed by Karnali Province at Rs. 243,796.

On the other hand, Madhes Province had the lowest average annual operating cost per establishment at just Rs. 126,801 followed by Koshi at Rs. 155,283.

The annual operating cost per establishment in Gandaki Province stood at Rs. 238,728, in Lumbini, it was Rs. 181,970 and in Sudurpashchim Province it was Rs. 229,399.

The NSO said that wholesale trade establishment witnessed the highest operating cost per establishment amounting to Rs. 1,314,379, followed by motor trade and repair, incurring Rs. 583,393 and retail trade at Rs. 219,240.

The data revealed that at the national level, on average, 74 per cent of such trade establishments were owned by males while 26 per cent were owned by females.

Nepal, Australia sign trade...

services to Nepal, read another statement issued by the Embassy of Australia in Kathmandu.

Flourishing people-to-people links between the two countries have created a solid foundation for growing, mutually beneficial economic relations. The Nepali diaspora community numbers more than 150,000 and is well-placed to further develop bilateral economic and commercial opportunities. Sectors such as tourism and hospitality, Nepal's emerging information and communications technology sector and agribusiness show particular promise.

Minister Saud attended a Luncheon hosted by Minister Wong in honour of the participating Ministers for Foreign Affairs in the Seventh Indian Ocean Conference. The TIFA represents an important milestone as Australia and Nepal celebrate 64 years of bilateral relations in February 2024.

SOUTH AFRICAN PRESIDENT DEFENDS 30 YEARS OF ANC RULE

AP
Cape Town, South Africa, Feb. 9

President Cyril Ramaphosa insisted Thursday that his ruling African National Congress party is making progress in addressing South Africa's problems such as record unemployment, an electricity crisis and corruption allegations that have even dented his own reputation.

Ramaphosa's nearly two-hour State of the Nation speech to Parliament was largely a defense of his first term in office — and the ANC's 30 years in government — ahead of elections later this year.

Several polls suggest the party once led by Nelson Mandela could lose its majority this year in what would be a landmark moment for South Africa.

The ANC has been in government ever since the end of the apartheid system of racial segregation in 1994, but its reputation as South Africa's liberator has been eroded and its support has gradually declined.

"Just as we cannot deny the progress South Africans have made over the last 30 years, nor should we diminish the severe challenges that we continue to face," Ramaphosa said.

Literature Festival to be held in Pokhara



BY OUR CORRESPONDET
Pokhara, Feb. 9

The 11th edition of Surya Nepal Literature Festival is scheduled to be held in Pokhara from February 15.

Organised by Bookworm Foundation, the festival is set to feature 58 sessions at Lakeside near Phewa Lake.

The organisers held a press conference in Pokhara on Thursday and said that the preparations for the festival reached the final stage.

The 11th edition of this festival will last until February 19. There will be more than two hundred speakers at the festival.

Keshav Sharan Lamichhane, a member of the organising committee, informed that literature, art, music, journalism, economics and politics would be discussed at the festival.

"From the problems that surfaced in cooperatives to the problems of Nepali literature and economy are included," he said.

About a dozen foreign writers and scholars, including American writer Kai Budde and sociologist George Bramley, are scheduled to participate in the festival.

In this year's festival, two days of special sessions have been reserved for students, informed the organiser.

Niraj Bhari, a member of the foundation, said that there would be a musical programme every evening.

Former Chief Justice Kalyan Shrestha will come for a scholarly speech at the opening of the festival. On the same occasion, artist Durga Baral's book 'Watsyayan' will be released.

Andra Day prays through nervousness ahead of Super Bowl performance

AP
Las Vegas, Feb. 9s

Andra Day normally deals with nervousness before any big show — especially in front of her peers. But the Grammy winner eventually leans on prayer to settle her anxiety.

On Sunday, Day will certainly use the same approach before she graces the Super Bowl stage as a pregame performer. She's set to perform " Lift Every Voice and Sing " ahead of the Kansas City Chiefs matchup against the San Francisco 49ers at Allegiant Stadium.

"I'm a praying person. I'm a deeply spiritual person. Prayer is huge," the soul singer told The Associated Press Thursday afternoon. Along with Day's performance, other pregame performers include country music star Reba McEntire who will sing the national anthem, while Post Malone will perform "America the Beautiful." Usher is the featured halftime performer.

Day certainly belongs. Last week, she earned a standing ovation after her performance at the Recording Academy's Black Music Collective event in Los Angeles. A couple days later at Clive Davis' pre-Grammy gala, she performed "That's What Friends Are For" and "What the World Needs Now is Love" onstage with Stevie Wonder, Gladys Knight, Dionne Warwick, Keyshia Cole and Frederic Yonnet.

> Day certainly belongs. Last week, she earned a standing ovation after her performance at the Recording Academy's Black Music Collective event in Los Angeles.

"If I'm here, I'm of the mindset that I'm called to be here," said Day, who's excited about hitting the Super Bowl stage in front of millions to perform "Lift Every Voice and Sing," a popular hymn known within the African American community.

"It's a huge moment," she said. "I don't want to just do well, but I really want people to encounter the spirit."

Day broke through with her standout single "Rise Up." She eventually won a Grammy and Golden Globe for her acting and musical work on the film "The United States vs. Billie Holiday."

After starring in the "Billie Holiday" and "The Deliverance" films, Day has re-focused her attention to making her own music. She recorded music while filming those projects and she's almost ready to reveal her second solo album "Cassandra," which is expected to release in the spring.

It'll be Day's first album since her 2015 debut "Cheers to the Fall," which earned a Grammy nomination along with " Rise Up."

On her upcoming album, Day wants to explore relationships and her spiritual walk with God. She'll also look to touch on her happiness and her not-so proud moments stemmed from selfish decisions.

Day said she wrote and sang through those experiences using it as her therapy.

"I wanted to show up as myself," she said. "Not necessarily do the right thing or say the right thing. I just want to show the iterations of me."

Day has already dropped two singles: "Where Do We Go" and "Probably," which explore the stories behind a breakup in a relationship. She said her upcoming project makes her feel like a new artist.

Dayarani and Hattichhap released in halls

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9





Two Nepali films, 'Dayarani' and 'Hattichhap' featuring actor Dayahang Rai in the lead roles, were simultaneously released in local theatres on Friday.

'Dayarani' stars Dayahang Rai, Deeya Pun, Bijay Baral, Puskar Gurung and others.

The movie was written and directed by Maoste Gurung.

'Hattichhap' features artists such as Dayahang Rai, Saugat Malla, Upasana Singh Thakuri, Benisha Hamal, Kamalmani Nepal, Bijay Baral and Buddhi Tamang. It is directed by Simos Sunuwar.

This marks the second time since April last year that Rai's films have been released simultaneously in the halls. Rai's films 'Jari' and 'Bihepass,' were released simultaneously on April 14 last year on the occasion of Nepali New Year.

These two films, grounded in village narratives, are likely to captivate the audience.

In addition to these Nepali offerings, Hindi film 'Teri Baaton Mein Aisa Uljha Jiya,' starring Shahid Kapoor and Kriti Sanon, was also released on Friday.

This film belongs to the romantic drama genre.

Spike Lee and Denzel Washington to reunite in remake of 'High and Low'

AGENCIES
Los Angeles, Feb. 9





Hollywood filmmaker Spike Lee and actor Denzel Washington are set to collaborate once again for the English-language remake of Akira Kurosawa's classic film, 'High and Low.' The project, a joint venture between Apple Original Films and A24, is scheduled to commence production in March, as per reports from entertainment outlet Variety.

Spike Lee, known for his previous collaboration with Denzel Washington on the 2006 film 'Inside Man,' will direct the adaptation, having co-written the script with Alan Fox. The film is a collaborative effort between A24, Escape Artists, and Mandalay Pictures.

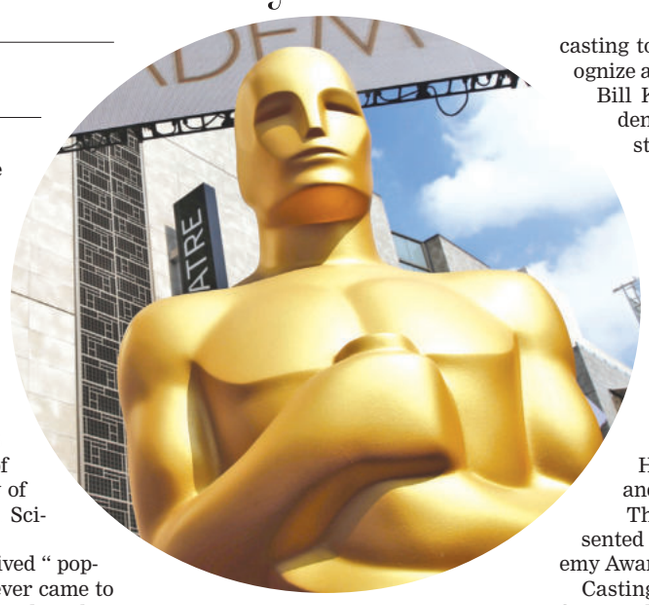
The original 'High and Low,' loosely based on Ed McBain's novel 'King's Ransom,' was released in 1963 and featured Toshiro Mifune as Kingo Gondo, a wealthy individual who plunges into debt to pursue a risky takeover and becomes the target of kidnappers.

The remake will be produced by Todd Black for Escape Artists and Jason Michael Berman for Mandalay Pictures. Spike Lee, serving as an executive producer through his production company 40 Acres And A Mule Filmworks, will be joined by Mandalay's Peter Guber, Juniper Productions' Matthew Lindner, Chris Brigham, and Katia Washington.

This reunion marks the latest collaboration between Spike Lee and Denzel Washington, following their previous successful projects such as 'Mo' Better Blues' (1990), 'Malcolm X' (1992), 'He Got Game' (1998), and 'Inside Man' (2006).

Oscars will add Academy Award for casting directors

AP
Los Angeles, Feb. 9



Casting directors are some of the most important creatives in entertainment but have never been celebrated as such on Hollywood's biggest night. Starting next year, however, that all changes.

The Oscars will add a new award to recognize achievement in casting for films released in 2025 and beyond, the board of governors of the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences said Thursday.

Not counting the short-lived " popular film Oscar " which never came to be, this is the first time the academy has added a category since best animated feature film was established in 2001.

"Casting directors play an essential role in filmmaking, and as the Academy evolves, we are proud to add casting to the disciplines that we recognize and celebrate," Academy CEO Bill Kramer and Academy President Janet Yang said in a joint statement.

The casting directors' branch was created in July 2013 and currently has nearly 160 members.

"This award is a deserved acknowledgment of our casting directors' exceptional talents and a testament to the dedicated efforts of our branch," said Academy Casting Directors Branch governors Richard Hicks, Kim Taylor-Coleman and Debra Zane in a statement.

The first statuette will be presented starting with the 98th Academy Awards in 2026.

Casting directors, and stunt performers, have long lobbied for an Oscar category to recognize their specific contributions to film. But for now, the stunts will have to wait.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: A big money move may be tempting to you now. As clever Mercury in your social zone challenges abundant Jupiter in your finance sector, the prospect of impressing your friends could be a big part of the motivation.

CANCER: Deciding how much personal information to share with your friends will potentially be difficult today. While candid Mercury in your intimacy zone stumbles over exaggerated Jupiter in your social 11th house.

LIBRA: You may urgently crave more freedom to express yourself. A get-rich-quick scheme could appear to be an appealing way to achieve that. When the spontaneous Moon encounters depressing Saturn in your 6th House of Responsibilities.

CAPRICORN: You may be fascinated by a big idea involving money as of late. As you dig into it, you probably need to be very clear in how you communicate so you don't lead anyone on to believe you're making a commitment.

TAURUS: You may feel excited about pursuing an ambitious goal at this time. Unfortunately, as the impressionable Moon meets gloomy Saturn in your social sector.

LEO: A personal relationship of yours could be causing trouble in your ongoing professional life. You potentially need to be clearer about your boundaries, but agonizing over how you should have seen this conflict coming.

SCORPIO: Working through a home or family problem could currently require your focused concentration. Unfortunately, the presence of an overbearing and opinionated person may be throwing off your thought process.

AQUARIUS: Ambitious plans for improving your home could be immediately tempered by your awareness of how much you're willing to spend. While the impulsive Moon meets restrictive Saturn in your finance zone.

GEMINI: Exploring your spiritual side could be especially exciting for you at present. As the vulnerable Moon joins stable Saturn in your 10th House of Reputation, you might be interested in making a public declaration.

VIRGO: Figuring out your priorities could be a challenge at the moment. While busy Mercury in your responsible 6th house restricts fun-loving Jupiter in your 9th House of Adventure.

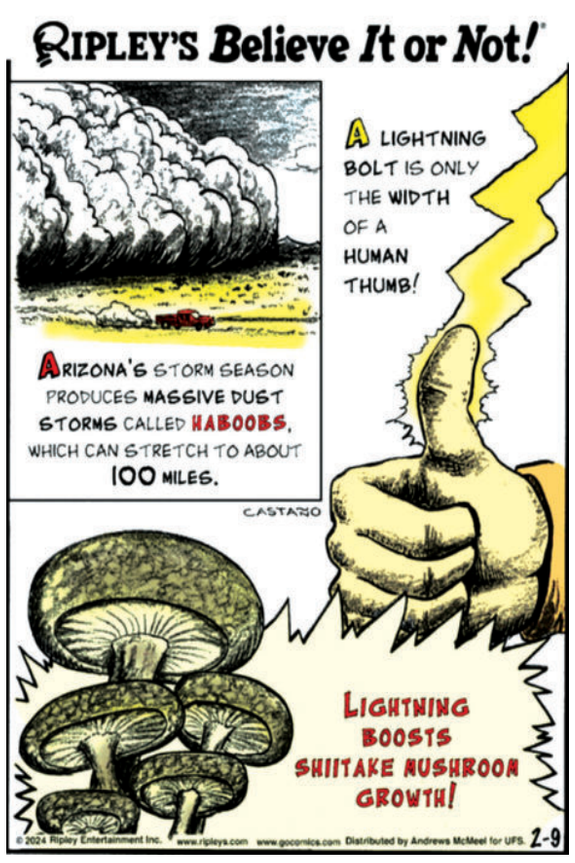
SAGITTARIUS: Talking in a way that exaggerates your capabilities is genuinely possible. Before your boasting gets you called upon to deliver things you can't handle, you might want to stop.

PISCES: Keeping up a poker face may feel necessary throughout your day. You might appear quiet and reserved, but it's possible that you're engaged in quite a bit of gossip under the radar.

CARTOON

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Three nominees shortlisted for NSJF Pulsar Sports Award

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9



The nominees have been shortlisted for 'best female player', 'best male player', 'best youth player' and 'best coach' awards.

The Nepal Sports Journalist Forum (NSJF) shortlisted three nominees each under four different categories for the NSJF Pulsar Sports Award 2079 being held on Sunday.

Organising a press conference, NSJF informed that the nominees were shortlisted for 'best female player', 'best male player', 'best youth player' and 'best coach' awards.

The NSJF had earlier nominated eight individuals each in the four categories. Of them, three shortlisted ones were made public on Friday.

"Three persons have been selected out of the eight nominees in the four categories based on their performances in the Nepali year 2079 B.S.," said Prajwal Oli, general secretary at NSJF.

Eight athletes nominated for the 'Best Male Player Award' were Deepak Adhikari (athletics), Aasif Sheikh (cricket), Mukesh Pal (athletics), Rohit Paudel (cricket), Nasir Yahya Hussain (swimming), Man Bahadur Shrestha (volleyball), Subash Tamang (golf), Rupesh Jaiswal (chess) were the nominees named for. Of them, Deepak, Aasif and Rohit have been shortlisted.

Narrowing down the eight athletes nominated for the 'Best Female Player Award', Anusha Malla (basketball), Pushpa Bhandari (athletics) and Rajpura Pachhai (athletics) have been picked. Punam Shrestha (Judo), Jayarani Tharu (athletics), Shrebee Maharjan (triathlon), Duwana Lama (swimming) and Amisha Karki (basketball) were the other female players in the category.

The eight youths nominated for the 'Best Young Player Award' were Rammaya Budha (athletics), Sushma Tamang (boxing), Sujata Tamang (football), Unesh Budhathoki (football), Bijay Bata (boxing), Dev Khanal (cricket), Dipesh Kandel (cricket) and Sadbhav Acharya (golf). Of them, Dev, Rammaya and Sushma have been selected as the best three.

Regarding the coaches, Chandra Gurung (athletics), Dipak Maharjan (boxing), Bhagwati Rana Magar (football), Ananta Raj Thapa (football), Bharat Shah (volleyball), Ongden Lama (swimming), Jagat Tamata (cricket) and Monty Desai (cricket) were nominated at first. "Chandra, Dipak and Jagat have been shortlisted for the 'Best Coach Award'," the organisers informed.

'Peoples' Choice' voting till Saturday midnight

Footballer Ananta Tamang, karate player Biplov Lal Shrestha, volleyball player Niruta Thagunna, table tennis player Sikka Suwal Shrestha and bodybuilder Rajani Shrestha were nominated for the 'Peoples' Choice Award' in January.

According to NSJF, with the award ceremony on Sunday evening, sports fans can vote for their favourite athlete until Saturday midnight. Sports enthusiasts can vote from eSewa and social media (NSJF Pulsar Sports Award and Pulsar Nepal's Facebook pages).

Votes from eSewa will share a value of 50 per cent while those from social media are valued at 25 per cent. Likewise, the votes from head coaches of 27 games, those which Nepal plays on the global stage, and NSJF members will have a value of 12.5 per cent each while selecting the winner of the 'Peoples' Choice Award'.



Warner leads the charge as Australia beat West Indies in T20 opener

AGENCIES
Hobart, Feb. 9

Australia have beaten the West Indies by 11 runs in Hobart in their first T20 international match.

David Warner laid the groundwork for the Australian victory, smashing 70 from 36 balls in his 100th T20 international as Australia posted an imposing 7-213.

In reply, the visitors could only manage 8-202, their middle order unable to capitalise on a flying start from openers Brandon King (53 runs off 37 balls) and Johnson Charles (42 off 25).

Warner, coming off a stint in the 20-over league in the United Arab Emirates, also got Australia off to a flying start with a 93-run opening partnership with Josh Inglis.

Opening together for the first time in T20 internationals, the pair had Australia 0-77 after the six-over powerplay before Tim David went to town late with an unbeaten 37 from 17 balls.

Warner finished with 12 fours and one six, but had some luck on 48 when wicketkeeper Nicholas Pooran grassed a tough opportunity diving one-handed.

Inglis also had a life when Brandon King spilled a half-chance in the outfield, but departed soon after in the eighth over for 39 from 25 balls.

Warner, who set the tone with four boundaries off Jason Holder in the second over, fell in the 13th when he gloved an Alzarri Joseph delivery to Pooran.

Australia were 5-159 in the 16th over after losing 4-30 before David combined with Matthew Wade for a partnership of 50 off 23 balls.

Andre Russell (3-42 from four overs) picked up Wade (21 from 14 balls) and Sean Abbott for a first-ball duck in the final over.

West Indies, who won the toss and elected to bowl at Blundstone Arena, are coming off a horror ODI loss to Australia in which they were dismissed for 86.

Australia's three T20s against the West Indies are followed by a three-game away series against New Zealand ahead of the World Cup in June.

The tourists have welcomed back big guns Russell, Holder, Pooran and Akeal Hosein after the quartet missed the recent ODI matches.

Australia recall Neser

Seamer Michael Neser was recalled Friday for Australia's upcoming two-Test series against New Zealand in a 14-man squad that otherwise had no surprises. The 33-year-old got the nod ahead of young quick Lance Morris, who suffered a side strain during last week's one-day clash against West Indies in Canberra.

But his chances of adding to the two Tests he has played are slim, with Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood once again the frontline fast bowlers.

"It's great to see Michael Neser get another opportunity in the squad following his ever-consistent performances over a long period of time and the conditions we expect," said chief selector George Bailey.

"We expect this tour will be a tough challenge against a very strong side who have been so consistent at home for a long period of time."

The series, starting February 29 in Wellington, is Australia's first overseas Test assignment since David Warner retired, with Steve Smith again set to open with Usman Khawaja.

NEPAL FACING HK TODAY AT ACC WOMEN'S T20 PREMIER CUP

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9

Nepal's women's cricket team is beginning its campaign at the ACC Women's T20 Premier Cup in Malaysia facing Hong Kong on Sunday. The match kicks off at 7:15 am Nepali time.

Out of the four groups of four teams each, Nepal and Hong Kong are in Group D with Bhutan and the Maldives. The 14-member women's team led by captain Indu Barma with Manoj Katwal was bid farewell by the officials from the Cricket Association of Nepal on Thursday.

Speaking in the farewell ceremony, the coach and captain expressed great determination to advance as far as they can in the tournament.

Nepal will face Bhutan on February 11 and the Maldives on February 13. The top two teams from each group will qualify for the quarter-finals.

Squad: Indu Barma, Bindu Rawal, Rubina Chhetry, Sita Rana Magar, Kajol Shrestha, Puja Mahato, Sangita Rai, Apsari Begam, Kabita Joshi, Kabita Kunwar, Samjhana Khadka, Roma Thapa, Dolly Bhatta, Ashmina Karmacharya.

Nepali young guns facing China Yushu Youth today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Feb. 9



A young Nepali men's football team is facing Yushu Youth, a team from China's Qinghai Province, at a friendly match on the occasion of the Chinese New Year at Dasharath Stadium on Saturday.

The Chinese team arrived in Kathmandu on Wednesday for the friendly. According to Chinese officials, it is the first time that the youth team, which is achieving great heights within the nation, travelling abroad.

Speaking at a pre-match conference on Friday, Coach of Yushu informed that they looked forward to the match which will strengthen the friendly ties between the two neighbours.

China's Yushu city has been evolving in football. Moreover, a youth football school was also established there in 2017 for the purpose.

During the conference, Nepal's head coach Vincenzo Alberto Annese said the friendly will be a good opportunity for the new players. "More than 24 senior players have gone abroad. In this situation, I believe the young players will give their best. Special attention has been given to the training as a team we got only eight days for the training."

Nepal has prepared an under-23 team for the friendly match.

Manish Dangi will be leading the team that consists of Ayush Ghalan, Puja Hona, Ajay Choudhary, Padam Bhattarai, Chhiring Lama, Yogesh Gurung, Bishal Basnet, Samir Tamang, Prashant Laksham, Sanjeeb Bista, Laken Limbu, Utsav Rai, Santosh Khatri, Rohan Karki, Chandan Kumar, Bishal Sunar, Kushal Deuba, Sumit Shrestha, Ashik Babu, Santosh Mahat, Niranjan Dhami and Anjal Maharjan.

FRANCE, ITALY, BELGIUM AND ISRAEL DRAWN IN NATIONS LEAGUE GROUP

AP
Paris, Feb. 9

World Cup runner-up France, European champion Italy, Belgium and Israel were drawn together in a tough group Thursday for the men's UEFA Nations League that starts in September.

The Nations League is the next action for UEFA member countries after this summer's European Championship, where France, Italy and Belgium — all top-10 teams in the FIFA world rankings — have qualified for the tournament in Germany and Israel is in the playoffs next month.

Nations League champion Spain was drawn in a group with Denmark plus Switzerland and Serbia who will resume a strong rivalry that was fueled by Swiss wins in their games at the past two World Cups.

Euro 2024 host Germany is in a Nations League top-tier group with Netherlands, Hungary and Bosnia-Herzegovina. Croatia was top-seeded in a group with Portugal, Poland and Scotland.

England is ranked No. 3 by FIFA yet was relegated from the top-tier Nations League group in 2022 and will face Finland, Greece and Ireland. It will be the first competitive match between England and Ireland since 1991.

"I think everybody in England will think it was a big disappointment to drop down to League B but you still have difficult games," coach Gareth Southgate said.

Group-stage games in all four tiers are played from September to November.

In top-tier League A, the top two teams in each group advance to the quarterfinals in March 2025. The semifinals and final are a mini-tournament hosted by one of the competing countries.

The Final Four is scheduled June 4-8, 2025, before many players return to their clubs for the inaugural 32-team Club World Cup in the United States. That month-long FIFA tournament starts June 15, 2025.

WEATHER

Saturday

Sunrise at 6:46 am, Sunset at 5:51 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Saturday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Friday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dipayal	22.0	5.5	0.0
Dadeldhura	15.0	3.6	0.0
Dhangadi	21.5	7.8	0.0
Birendranagar	21.8	5.9	0.0
Nepalgunj	22.8	6.8	0.0
Jumla	18.4	-5.5	0.0
Ghorahi	19.0	8.7	0.0
Pokhara	20.0	10.8	0.0
Bhairahawa	22.5	8.5	0.0
Simara	22.7	6.5	0.0
Kathmandu	18.2	3.4	0.0
Okhaldhunga	14.0	4.8	0.0
Taplejung	16.6	4.2	0.0
Dhankuta	21.0	6.5	0.0
Biratnagar	24.0	8.2	0.0
Jomsom	13.1	-2.0	0.0*
Dharan	24.4	10.9	0.0*
Lumle	12.5	4.6	0.0*
Janakpur	25.0	8.0	0.0*
Jiri	14.0	-2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

February 10, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.56	Rs. 133.16
Euro	1	Rs. 142.74	Rs. 143.39
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 167.11	Rs. 167.87
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 151.41	Rs. 152.10
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 86.29	Rs. 86.68
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 98.52	Rs. 98.97
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 98.47	Rs. 98.92
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 8.87	Rs. 8.91
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.43	Rs. 18.51
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.35	Rs. 35.51
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.35	Rs. 36.52
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.69	Rs. 3.71
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.09	Rs. 36.26
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 27.82	Rs. 27.95
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 9.96	Rs. 10.00
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 12.65	Rs. 12.71
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.15	Rs. 19.23
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.95	Rs. 17.03
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 430.31	Rs. 432.25
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 351.64	Rs. 353.23

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Fraser-Pryce to retire after Paris Olympics 2024



AFP
Miami, Feb. 9

Jamaican sprint legend Shelly-Ann Fraser-Pryce, a three-time Olympic gold medalist and 10-time world champion, said she will retire after this year's Paris Olympics in an interview published Thursday.

Speaking to the American magazine Essence, Fraser-Pryce said she is forcing herself to retire at age 37 to spend more time with her family.

"My son needs me," Fraser-Pryce told the magazine. "My husband and I have been together since before I won in 2008. He has sacrificed for me. We're a partnership, a team.

"It's because of that support that I'm able to do the things that I've been doing for all these years. And I think I now owe it to them to do something else."

She is focusing on her training for one last chance at Olympic glory in France, what Fraser-Pryce said is about "pushing boundaries" as well as "showing people that you stop when you decide.

"I want to finish on my own terms."

Fraser-Pryce has won eight Olympic medals, including 100-meter gold at 2008 in Beijing and 2012 in London and a Tokyo Olympic title as part of Jamaica's 4x100 relay.

Her medal haul also includes silver at 100m in Tokyo and 200m in London plus a 2016 Rio 100m bronze.

She won 100m world titles in 2009, 2013, 2015, 2019 and 2022 plus a 200 world crown in 2013 and 4x100 relay golds in 2009, 2013, 2015 and 2019.

"There's not a day I'm getting up to go practice and I'm like, 'I'm over this,'" Fraser-Pryce said.

Published by Executive Chairman **Bishnu Prasad Subedi** and General Manager **Lal Bahadur Airi** for the Gorkhapatra Corporation • Printed at G.S. Press, Kathmandu • Acting Editor-in-Chief: **Bhimsen Thapaliya**
Phone: Editorial 5322279 • Advertisement 5327493, 5331394 • Distribution 5320638 • E-mail: mgorkhapatra@gmail.com, trnfeatures@hotmail.com • Registered No. 29/028/022 • G.P.O. 30/053/54